Journey to Mor Pankh

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The Stargazers

JMP-01

???: Hypotheses have been made regarding the quasars as follows ...

The hall was packed with audience members.

exhales

The darkness below the podium is boiling. The eyes with questions and inspection, some behind glasses, are cast out of the darkness.

Just like the signals beamed from several light years away and received at the top of the observatory.

???: Good.

???: Based on the data of its redshift, Dr. Schmidt deduced that it is moving away from us at a recessional velocity of 1/6 of light speed.

Page 3, mmm, I did put it in ...

???: In most cases, we would consider a stellar black hole as what is left from the gravitational collapse of a star.

The red chalk left a jaggy circle in one stroke on the blackboard.

???: They fight, attract each other, and merge into a supermassive black hole to which the stars in the nearby galaxies will be eventually pulled by gravity ...

Page 3, oh, here it is. Did Kumar put it here for me?

"Then there was neither existence nor non-existence; there was neither the realm of space nor the sky beyond."

???: *"Then there was neither death nor immortality; there was neither day nor night."*

???: Inside the quasars, there is a violent activity occurring that is close to a supernova.

???: It devours stars ...

???: And the gas cloud turns into stars out of gravitational driving.

???: Thus, a new star is born.

???: It is a graveyard filled with corpses.

???: As well as a cradle for new stars.

Meadow

The evening breeze, the meadow, and the fresh air. Despite its lack of privacy, this was as good a place to chill as it could be.

It was a clear night. Stars twinkled in the sky like golden sprinkles on a dark cloth.

???: That was a successful lecture, Kaalaa Baunaa.

Kaalaa Baunaa heard a familiar voice and recognized the footsteps. Without looking back, she already knew who was behind her.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Thanks for your rare compliment.

She extended her arm, reaching out for the stars.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I can't believe the first thing you do after the long absence is listening to my embarrassing speech.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You see, this is not my thing. I'm still struggling with a word I should use in Part 3.

???: Oh, but you know I won't pass up a good chance to sit in the audience ...

The grass rustled. She lay down next to Kaalaa Baunaa.

???: ... to be someone who can smile knowingly at the argument made by the lecturer, knowing full well the thinking process behind, while staying close to other whispering opinions.

???: This is the perfect spot for observations, like a perfect observatory from which we witness the events in the universe!

Kaalaa Baunaa: I'd rather not give a comment on your personal taste. Kumar, I think we should make some adjustments to the details of the following observation.

Kumar: Here's an idea. How about we put away the work for the moment? Forget those things. Just look at the stars. Simply fix your eyes on them. Ah, move over. The grass beneath me feels like pine needles.

Kaalaa Baunaa: When you were away, Daane from the institution had paid a visit here. Based on his attitude, I may tell he was doubting my identity as a human.

Kumar: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: If it goes on like this, we are likely to be kicked out of our own project.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I've destroyed all the observation data of that special celestial body. At least through this, we can keep the observation method between you and me.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Her words were only met with a lasting silence. Kaalaa Baunaa turned to the person next to her.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You seem ... Have I done anything wrong?

Kumar: No. As a research student, you did an excellent job, though no more than I'd expect from a student of mine.

Her voice was incredibly calm.

Kumar: That's just what we've been doing, isn't it? Hiding in the corners, doing research that **completely** has nothing to do with others.

Kumar: You know what? I'm a bit tired, seriously, tired of the pointless power struggles between these specks of "stardust." We all know none of us could avoid the fate of being restored to the basic elements of the universe after we die.

She sighed deeply at the thought.

Kumar: Never mind. It's not the first time it's happened. I've never been welcomed on either side.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kumar: Ah, speaking of which ...

Hooked by the conversation, unpleasant memories swam up again.

Kumar: My parents, yeah, I told you about them. They abandoned me because I had little so-called talent for arcanum.

Kumar: And now, they are showing remorse for what they have done!

Kumar: There's more—my stupid younger brother knew nothing about what happened to me. He didn't even recognize me, his own sister!

Kaalaa Baunaa: You paid them a visit this time back in your hometown?

Kumar: Visit them? No, sweetheart, I went home to ... to do many things except to hear some old people's apology! I've never cared about those things.

Kumar: I went there to deal with a little business, and it was done smoothly.

She seemed to be in a state of ease.

Kumar: So smoothly that I've taken care of everything there is to be done.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...?

Kumar: Kaalaa Baunaa, if ...

A gust of wind blew by the meadow. The subtle sound of plant fibers rubbing against each other could be heard clearly.

Kumar: If one day, we can see that celestial body with our own eyes, or even touch it with our own hands, I will definitely ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kumar?

Kaalaa Baunaa: What are you talking ab- ...

Kaalaa Baunaa propped herself up on both of her elbows, trying to see the one beside her clearly.

But that person's face was indistinguishable, as if hidden in a thick black fog.

Kumar: I WILL DEFINITELY ...!

Kaalaa Baunaa: KUMAR!

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...!

3#1

Yellow Crystal Pendulum

JMP-02

Matilda: Excuse me.

Matilda: Let me get through!

Train Station, Mor Pankh, 1966

Matilda: Ah! Will you move, please? For the sake of Marie Anne Lenormand!

The crowds on the platform are like schools of colorful sardines, pushing each other toward their destinations at an incredible speed.

Matilda: Oh, finally! Ah-ah, ouch, this train ride gave me a real pain in the neck!

She finally gets to relax in one of the few empty seats in the station.

Matilda: How nice it'd be if I were to sleep on my bed in such cool and comfortable weather! Or I may as well just stay in Delhi with Mom to sell those topazes!

Matilda: *sighs*

Her fist tightens, though she doesn't consciously want to. The documents rattle in her hand.

She looks down at the documents.

Matilda: ...

Matilda: No! Matilda will not just give up here!

Matilda: Who knows when they will approve my leave next time?

Matilda: These days, the celestial energy appears to be ideally strong, and the best observation area happens to be close to Delhi. What a heaven-sent opportunity for this genius of divination! Only the fools will take no action!

Matilda: Wait and see. When I find the right place to meditate ...

She slightly shakes her fist. It seems she has made up her mind very seriously.

Matilda: Hum-humph, sooner or later, I will take my ride back to the top!

She rummages through the documents and moves close enough to read the poorly printed text.

Matilda: Emm, let me see what this poster is about. Emm, Dīpa Festival?

She turns over the poster.

Matilda: *"People in Mor Pankh hold the Dīpa Festival during the meteor shower period every year to seek the blessings of Vindre."*

Matilda: Oh, so it's based on the meteor shower here! Vindre ... I think I have seen this name in the materials.

Matilda: Now I'm in the east of Chandigarh. Can there be fewer signs here?

Matilda: Ah-ha! This map has English on its back! Very nice. Would be more classy if they put French here instead.

Matilda: The place I found through divination is called Mor Pankh. It's a shrine! I need to go to its north cave?

Matilda: Good. So, a shrine. Perhaps it has something to do with that comet myth I read about earlier. Isn't this also one of the places to see the upcoming meteor shower?

Matilda: Great! This is where I am going, then. Where's my pen? Ah, here! Very good, let me put it down.

She hunches over and writes down something carefully.

Matilda: Phew! Nicely done! Everything is a lot more convenient in the new town.

The ceiling looks new. This train station seems to have been built not too long ago.

Matilda: Looks a lot better than the ceiling in Delhi's train station. I wonder how Mom and Dad are doing now. That Indian man can speak really fast when he's bargaining.

Matilda: Emm.

As she slackens off, tiredness catches up with her.

Matilda: Emm. Just one quick nap, very brief ...

Matilda: ... Zzz ...

???: Wow, cool! What a bold girl!

???: Hee hee ...

???: Guys, you see that? The girl brave enough to sleep in the train station.

Ajar: Err, I see nothing, Boss! Not everyone has the great eyesight as yours. Oh, thank you. Nice monocular.

Ajar: Oh, shiny jewels and wallet.

Ajar: But what is the thing she is holding so tightly, even when she's asleep? Isn't that the map they give away at the train station for free?

Kanjira: Hmm, something valuable, I guess? Like the treasure map pictures in the books! If I can take a closer look ...

Kanjira: Well, that's too hard for you. Ajar, you go from left, just as I taught you. Give me this gesture after you get it.

Ajar: Heh-heh, no problem!

Kanjira: Do it well, boy! If you make it, that would be your first step to victory! Oh, remember, don't tell Ms. Sherjah I taught you these!

Kanjira: Go, go! Don't let other people get it before you do.

Matilda: Umm ...?

Matilda: What is it? Something swaying?

Sleepily, Matilda struggles to open her eyes and sees a little figure prowling away.

Ajar: Emm, ahem! Is this yours, Miss?

Matilda: Emm? Hey, that's the pendulum Mom gave me! Who are you?

Ajar: It fell on the floor. I was just picking it up for you! There, don't lose it again.

Matilda: Oh! Thank you ...

Matilda reaches for the pendulum.

???: Nuh-uh. It's yet too early to say thanks, girl.

Matilda: Hmm?

Shamane: They find themselves in the shadow of a tall man.

Shamane: The man seems travel-worn, but he's carrying just a little luggage.

???: About three minutes ago? Or, five minutes ago? This fellow was wandering around you like a sneaky ferret-badger. Trust me. This is no friendly encounter.

He raises his left hand, more specifically, his prosthesis, to show the delicate wallet between those seemingly stiff fingers.

Matilda: Umm? That's mine. You! You stole my wallet?!

Ajar: Wha, what? I've put it in my pocket.

???: Someone needs to work on his techniques, right, boy?

The man catches Ajar's clothes—this time with his real hand—and easily picks him up.

Ajar is lifted in the air, but he isn't strangled with his collar, for the man has skillfully avoided the area of his neck.

Ajar: Let go! Let go of me! D**n it! Go mind your own business!

???: Unfortunate for you, my business these days is to mind others' business. Seems like there are more things in that pocket of yours. Come on, you know where we are going.

Ajar: Ah! Urrrh!

Ajar shows his teeth and bites the man hard on the right hand, which is dragging his collar.

???: Hiss—ah!

He lets go because of the pain. The little thief breaks free and quickly slips into the crowd.

Matilda: He's gotten away. My, my, my pendulum! He had my pendulum. Stop! You!

Ajar: *pants* D**n it! They are catching up!

Matilda: Stop right there, you little thief!

Ajar: Humph!

The annoyed boy throws the pendulum into the distance with full strength.

???: Ah, you, boy! Wait!

The man runs into the colorful schools of sardines in hot pursuit.

Matilda: You! No! It's fragile. Don't!

In a beautiful arc, the transparent topaz falls toward the ground like a meteor.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...!

Suddenly, a palm appears and catches it safely.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Phew. Just in time.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Is this yours?

Matilda: Ah, yes.

The lady leans forward and speaks in a soft voice. Matilda stares into her eyes, completely abstracted.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Put it away, kid.

As she tilts her palm, the topaz falls swiftly into Matilda's hand.

Matilda: Ah, thank you.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's okay.

The lady slightly nods and leaves like a gust of wind.

Matilda: She left so quickly.

Matilda: Ah, the documents. Hope I didn't mess them up in the chase.

Matilda: One, two, emm? Two pages are missing. Where did they go?

A small, black-haird head is peeking from behind a pillar nearby.

Kanjira: Thankfully, I've planned my way out in advance. Well, at least Ajar won't be caught by anyone!

Kanjira: Good luck running away, poor Ajar.

She puts her palms together and wobbles her head to show her pity.

Kanjira: I will make a profit from her, including the part you failed to make. Humph, that easy mark with milky blonde hair, you'll see how Kanjira ...

Kanjira: Whoa! What did I step on?

Kanjira: Is this the thing she was looking at? Yes, my eyes won't fail me.

Her face puckers up as she examines the paper in front of her.

Kanjira: It really is a treasure map! Look here. She even drew a star, just like those pictures in books.

Kanjira: You lucky girl, Kanjira. This is really something valuable!

Kanjira: Let me see. Oh, I have to read it together with the handwritten notes. What are these, hmm? She spelled these all wrong! Even added some lines above them.

Matilda: Don't even bother trying. It's in French!

Kanjira: Hey! Don't even think about taking my treasure, oh.

Matilda squints to scan the suspect, who is trying to avoid eye contact.

Matilda: What were you muttering about with my map?

Kanjira: Emm, ahem.

Kanjira: I, uh, just pick it up and look for its owner. Hope I can help!

Matilda: Help? Humph! Matilda needs no one's help! Not to mention from a girl who just showed up out of nowher- ... Hey! Don't ... don't touch me!

Kanjira ignores Matilda's contempt. She holds Matilda's arm intimately, with a big smile on her face.

Kanjira: Wow, you is so cool!

Kanjira: Is this your first time in the village? On your own? What's the plan? Sightseeing? Family visit? Or looking for some ...

Matilda: Hey! Let go first. Why's that any of your business?

Kanjira: Umm, aha, I mean, perhaps not clear to you, but in fact, I am a guide who always give best service!

Matilda: A guide? Who always gives the best service?

Kanjira: A tour guide, maybe? Anyways, I tell you, nobody know this village better than I!

Kanjira: Hey, don't stare at me like this. I'm wandering here for a reason: I only give services to outstanding and cool people. They have good taste!

Kanjira: That why I find you at the station from all travelers! My most great, great customer ever!

Matilda: Ah! The outstanding and impressive people, you say. Humph, at least you have sharp eyes.

Matilda tries hard to suppress her complacent smile.

Kanjira: See, the place you is visiting is different from others!

Kanjira: This shrine, only few tourists are willing to ... ahem, only the locals know! And now, people can only go into three caves out of four. But, if you choose I ...

The black-haired girl reaches out and pats the map on the star.

Kanjira: I can take you go north cave, even if it's not open!

Matilda frowns in response. There is suspicion in her eyes.

Matilda: How are you going to take me there?

Kanjira: How, how I do that? Um, my local connections, of course!

Matilda: I see. No wonder there were some discrepancies between the documents and the tourist brochure. Ah-ahem, well, of course, I knew this all along!

Kanjira: Heh heh.

Matilda: Hmm? What are you laughing at?

Kanjira: No, no, no, my dear guest, it's just sneeze.

Kanjira: Well, you see, I just make a living here. I'm short and thin, can't compare with adults.

She tilts her head slightly—the angle is so perfect that it seems to be a result of countless practices—and sheds tears naturally.

Kanjira: And you is so great. You will not let I, weak poor kid, get hungry for no money, will you?

Matilda: Err. Even if you look at me with those puppy eyes ...

Kanjira: First sight I know, you is a lady with great taste, just like a sand cat, brave and smart.

Kanjira's downcast green eyes subtly steal a covert glance up at Matilda, secretly reading the signs on her face.

Matilda: Sand, sand cat? It does sound like a smart animal.

Kanjira: Anyways, you is lucky to meet me, my lady!

Kanjira waves her hands as if she has made a big decision.

Kanjira: Well, well, for a great customer like you, I can only suffer some loss! Just 200 rupees, and I'll show you the shrine and the whole Mor Pankh village! With a special Dīpa Festival tour on the house!

Kanjira: Want me to recommend a hotel? I know good hotels, too.

Kanjira: Yes or no, my dear guest? My most great guest? Please ...

Matilda: Fine, fine. I will allow you to be my temporary assistant, for your life has been so sad already.

Kanjira: Yay! Let's go treasure hunting, hmm, sightseeing!

Matilda: Excellent. Have you arranged a shuttle bus for the travel?

Kanjira: Heh heh, I have something gooder than bus for you!

Kanjira puts on a mysterious smile on her stained face.

Kanjira: And I promise you, quick like flash!

3#1

The Young Indiana Jones

JMP-03

Kanjira: Woo-hoo! Alright, sit tight!

Kanjira: Let's GO!!

Matilda: Waaaaah?!

Villager 1: *coughs* You little j**k again! D**n it, Sinha, for one last time, don't borrow that annoying human thing to her!

The bright-yellow tuk tuk drifts in a beautiful arc on the soft road, the brown sand kicked up in the air covering up the curses of the passer-by.

Matilda: Slow down, slow down! We are going too fast!

Matilda: Waaaah! Is this thing really under control?!

Kanjira: Hey!

As the tuk tuk roars along, the marigold petals are flying wildly in the wind.

Kanjira: Not yet best part! Hold that bar tight!

Matilda: Waaah ...

Street

Matilda: Whuu ... phew ...

Kanjira: Woo-hoo! How you feel, my guest?

Matilda: ...

Matilda: *vomits*

Kanjira: Oh, I'm sorry. You must not be used to this. Here, use it.

As Kanjira passes over the hem of her skirt, Matilda takes out a handkerchief from her pocket in silence.

Kanjira: If you want your silk dirty. Fine, you look very decent after all.

Kanjira: And, here it is.

The shrine is apparently an old one, judging by the worn bricks. The smell of sticky spices in the air is almost suffocating.

Matilda: What's this smell? Is it ... *coughs*

Kanjira: Smell of full white musk and sanders, calming palo santo and cinnamon. Hah! You feel your chakra open?

Kanjira: But, I can also smell, hmm, a lot of mango. That smells good.

Kanjira glances at the stone wall to measure its height and then nods.

Kanjira: Okay. Jump over this wall, and we are in!

Matilda: Jump over it?! I thought there is at least a hidden side door!

Kanjira: To see the closed cave, you must pay a price!

Matilda: Ah. So this is your "local connections"!

Kanjira: Um. Well, that mean tuk tuk, my guest! No tuk tuk this village is faster than that! Uncle Sinha is not so nice and lend me if I don't give him my lunch money!

Kanjira: My route don't need entrance ticket! Shouldn't you give me credit?

Even if she is busted, Kanjira is not embarrassed at all. On the contrary, she looks a bit proud. She puts her hands together to form a temporary "stepping stone."

Kanjira: Now come! Although I think you don't like this "rude" behavi- ...

Matilda: Humph!

Ignoring the "stepping stone," Matilda raises her arms and jumps up the wall deftly.

Kanjira: Hmm?

Matilda: I was thoughtful and considerate enough not to wipe my nose on your skirt, yet you repay my kindness with contempt. Climbing over a wall of this height is really a piece of cake!

Matilda: So? Do you need a hand getting up here?

Matilda looks down proudly from the top of the wall.

Kanjira: ...

Kanjira: Huh! Weirdo.

Mor Pankh Shrine

The shrine is shrouded in thick smoke and packed with pious believers, resembling a legged cloud with the smell of spices.

The two small figures sneak into the shadow in the corner while avoiding the believers in their way.

Matilda: I don't know what this skulking was for! You'd better not be lying!

Kanjira: Nom nom.

Matilda: Hey, what's that in your hand?!

Kanjira: You want a bite? The prayers are so pious, so don't worry, the fruits is tasty! Nom nom, like I expect, so sweet.

Matilda: When did you ... Did you take it from the offerings?!

Kanjira: Don't mind! Manka, come back.

A little black snake creeps up her arm quietly.

Kanjira: By the way, I hope you is not afraid of snakes. I'm a special kind.

Matilda: And I'm curious about what exactly you are referring to. Specially rude, or specially annoying?

Kanjira: Why so angr- ... I mean, um, I'm arcanist. Hope I don't scare you. Relax, I'm not like others.

Matilda: Are you serious? Can't you tell I'm also an excellent, one of the best, arcanist?

Matilda jumps up with a jerk out of excitement, but then she notices the crowds and has to crouch down again very quickly.

Matilda: So you were lying to me! Spoke about all those good virtues you can see in me.

Kanjira: Hey! It's not my fault! You doesn't look like one!

Kanjira drops the mango core and scans Matilda in slight surprise.

Kanjira: I thought all arcanists except me are like ...

Matilda: Like what?

Kanjira: Like the villagers, those old mans, yell when they see humans, like annoying monkeys or crowing chickens. They even drive humans away, don't care they is here to help.

Kanjira: Why you think only the train station is tidy and clean? Humans in other places is all drive away!

Kanjira: I'm not like them because ... Anyways, I never thought there is more arcanist like me.

Kanjira speaks in a quiet voice. A confused look appears on her face.

Matilda: Humph, if you ask me, I'd say you read too little and know too little.

Matilda: I suggest you follow my example and adopt the style of a real arcanist.

Kanjira: Fine, fine! Oh, Manka say there is just a few people outside, so up your head, stay confident, and walk out like we paid!

Matilda: ...

Matilda: Have you been listening or not?!

North Cave

Following Kanjira, Matilda goes through the smoke and arrives at the entrance to the cave.

Kanjira: Ha! Nice. Nobody around as usual!

Kanjira: But I still suggest you be careful, since ... Hmm, I understand the damage when digging. Just don't involve me if you must break something!

Matilda looks up, not hearing a word of her mutter.

Matilda: So this is "the Head of Vindre"?

The top of the cave looks like a black hole. No one knows where it will lead or what it will devour.

Kanjira: Tsk tsk, dark and scary. But this is what must go through on the way to treasure, just like you must say "Open Sesame," right?

Matilda: I really don't know what to make of this "treasure" you've been mumbling about. I hope you didn't get the wrong idea.

Kanjira: Ah. I see what you mean here. Relax. I will zip my lips and tell no one.

She zips her mouth shut and nods sincerely.

Kanjira: I'll just stay here, then. Everything good luck!

Matilda: Ah? Anyway, despite all the strange things you've been talking about along the way, you have successfully taken me here as promised. I guess here is where we part! Thank you.

After bidding her goodbye, Matilda turns around to walk toward the cave while browsing the documents in her hand.

Soon she is devoured by the bottomless darkness.

Kanjira: Sincerest wishes to you, my brave guest! Whether a giant snake or dragon, as long as you find the legendary treasure, we'll meet again! Hee hee.

Footsteps echo inside the cave like a piece of poorly composed percussion music.

Matilda: This mural seems to be related to that myth! Here, on this paper! Let me see.

There is a huge mural carved on the wall, spreading to the end of her sight.

She turns the pages of the notebook quickly.

Matilda: Found it! *"Before the Serpent struck in night sky, the stone house of Asura rose to the north of the Head of Vindre."*

Matilda: *"The master of the stone has acted, with countless feet, with countless eyes, to trip, to pry, in bringing the blessed house of men to rest."*

Matilda: Wow, impressive! Perhaps this is the origin of some arcane creature.

Matilda: "The Serpent struck," that is to say, the best time to practice on the celestial energy is when the comet goes across the sky?

Matilda: *"Long darkness reaches the men as the Serpent's tail reveals itself. Some are sent down the great slopes and never return ..."*

Matilda: *"... for desire is the infallible devourer. "*

Matilda: Desire, hmm, I should meditate before practice.

Matilda: *"The circle of everything ends at the tip of the great tail, all ..."*

THUD!

Matilda: ...!

The echo has disappeared.

Behind her, there is nothing but boundless darkness.

Matilda: Did I hear it wrong?

Matilda: No ...

Matilda: Come into the light! Who, who is there?

Her voice ripples out. Its echoes and the echoes of the echoes reverberate between the walls of the cave.

There is no response.

Matilda: This doesn't seem right.

Matilda: Was this statue posing like this earlier?

While Matilda is still wondering, the statues in her sights start to move.

Matilda: Aah!

The benevolent-looking statues, which were sitting in lotus position, are now struggling in a twisted way to break free from the wall.

Matilda: Not good! Time to retreat.

She turns around immediately and runs toward the exit, yet the ground is pulling her back like a rolling carpet.

Matilda: What?! Aah!

She can feel her chin hitting hard against the rock.

One arm, two, three, and more of them are growing out from both sides of the statues, each with a glossy eyeball embedded within.

Matilda: What? What is this!

Following the slight noise, every eye turns to the girl lying on the ground.

Matilda: Oh! Hurry up. Get yourself together! Think what you have learned and practiced in the past!

3#3

Intersecting Lines

JMP-04

Matilda: Aah, ouch, it hurts!

Matilda: How ... how come there are so many of them!

Like overgrown grass, more and more statues are coming out of the walls, no matter how many Matilda destroys.

Matilda lies against the sharp gravel on the ground. She covers her waist and gasps in pain.

Matilda: Not good, not good. Think, Matilda.

Blood is running out from between her fingers unstoppably, taking away her vitality like a water pump does.

The statue in front of her raises the umbrella in its hand.

Matilda: No, don't ...!

Her hands drenched in blood, she can no longer hold the orb.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Get on your feet!

Matilda: Hmm?

The moment she hears the strange voice, Matilda regains strength in her limbs.

Matilda: Aah!

She can't help but bounce up like a puppet controlled by some invisible threads.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Well done, little diviner.

Kaalaa Baunaa: &

Matilda: My legs, they heal themselves. Where are the wounds?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Close your eyes. Don't look at anything.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The illusions would destroy your will.

Matilda: Wait. That, that was ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: %

Matilda: *pants*

Silence and cold fall again, as if nothing has happened.

Matilda looks down at her legs, slapping them to check if she's dreaming.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

However, they are smooth, nimble, and healthy. There are no signs of injury on her skin other than the light red marks from the slaps.

Matilda: How come ...? Is it some kind of hallucinating arcane skill?

Matilda: You are the lady from the train station.

She looks at the lady in confusion.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Looks like part of our destinies are now tied together, kid.

Kaalaa Baunaa responds to her with a reassuring smile.

Kaalaa Baunaa: What are you doing here? I don't think this place is open to tourists.

Matilda: I ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...!

Something is churning imperceptibly in the dark.

Matilda: They are coming again!

Matilda: Is it another illusion?

Hands, hands, and more hands. The familiar dark-yellow statues are like newly hatched creatures, slimy and ugly. They are trying hard to break the shell of darkness.

Kaalaa Baunaa: No, they are not.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Please, stay behind me.

Kaalaa Baunaa sounds a bit confused.

Kaalaa Baunaa: They look ... real?

Matilda: Careful! Watch out! They are coming again! Move!

Kaalaa Baunaa: *coughs* Are you alright?

Hiding behind the rock, Kaalaa Baunaa carefully brushes away Matilda's milky blonde hair to find a wound.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Not illusions this time.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Too bad. D**n it! How did Kumar do this!

Matilda: Aarh! The pain ... What is happening now? I was only here for ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Sorry, but it's not the time for explaining.

Kaalaa Baunaa: We are at the exit soon. Remember, leave this village as soon as possible after you're out. Do not ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...!

Before she finishes the words, Kaalaa Baunaa seems to have sensed danger and immediately rolls to the side while covering Matilda's head.

Huge rocks fall to the ground. The rock they hid behind is now a pile of powder.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

The cave shakes under the strikes of the statues.

Matilda: Um.

???: Hey!

They hear a strange voice.

???: Watch your head!

Kaalaa Baunaa seems quite nervous; her arms are holding Matilda even more tightly.

A familiar figure leaps onto the statue's shoulder and raises his fist.

???: Hah!

The left half of the statue's face flies across the cave.

???: Huh, harder than I thought! Dad hadn't told me those statues could move.

???: Again!

The giant statue breaks into pieces under his fist and falls to the ground.

???: Whoa! That's dangerous!

???: Sorry. Though you have a very impressive appearance as a statue, your attitude and manner are problematic.

???: Hah!

Matilda: Waah!!

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa grips Matilda's sleeve gently, pulling her one step to the side.

The next moment, the falling rocks graze their hair and smash into the ground.

Matilda: Ugh!

The cave goes quiet again.

The debris of the statue piles up in front of them.

???: Hah-ah!

A huge rock is cast aside. The man emerges from the ruins, patting the dust off his broad shoulders.

???: Phew! I almost got killed.

???: Hey, you guys alright? These things are freaky!

As he speaks, he waddles down from the huge pile of rocks and walks toward Matilda.

???: So, do you know where they came from? My head almost got smashed when I reached the entrance.

He walks at a slow pace, but he keeps his tongue busy.

???: Hmm, it's been 11 or maybe 12 years since I left this place. I'm welcomed by these things as soon as I'm back. What a surprise, huh?

Matilda: ...?

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Matilda: Is he talking to us?

The man walks over to Matilda. His eyebrows are drawn together in bewilderment.

???: Mmm. Wait.

But quickly, his face brightens up.

???: Aren't you the little one from the train station? I helped get your stuff back, remember me?

The man quickly wipes his face, hoping that Matilda can see him more clearly.

Matilda: Huh? Oh!

The tall figure takes her back to the train station.

Matilda: It's you, the man bitten by the thief!

???: Yeah, that's me. That was one merciless bite.

He cracks a smile.

???: Ha! What a happy coincidence! Well, maybe this is not the best place for a reunion, but the occasion is not for us to decide.

Shamane: Oh, I should introduce myself this time. The name is Shamane. Sorry, I wasn't much of a helping hand earlier and let that kid get away. But this time, I have made it up to you, eh? Eh?

Matilda: Oh, emm.

Matilda casts a hesitant glance at the ruins.

Matilda: You have made it up, I guess?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Sorry to interrupt you.

Kaalaa Baunaa raises a hand and interrupts them.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But I think this place is safe only for now. It'd be a wise choice to leave as soon as possible.

She speaks a bit faster.

Kaalaa Baunaa: And I mean more than this cave. Actually, are you tourists? I'm hoping you can leave this village in a couple of days.

Matilda: Hmm?

Kaalaa Baunaa: I know this sounds weird, but you need to trust me.

She reaches inside the pocket of her coat and tries to take out a stack of files.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Huh? D**n, where's my ID? Ah!

Her finger slips, and the files litter the floor.

Shamane: Whoa, whoa, whoa. Easy, lady. Take your time. We're listening.

Shamane hunkers next to her, helping her pick up the files.

Shamane: Oh, here's your ID! Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa? Hold it.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Ah, thank you.

Kaalaa Baunaa reaches for the card, but he doesn't loosen his hand.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...?

Shamane points at her waist with a shocked look on his face.

She follows his gaze and looks down. A pair of tortoiseshell spectacles hangs on her belt, one temple broken.

Shamane: This is ... No, I can't be wrong.

Shamane: How come you have Kumar's stuff on your belt?

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...!

Without conscious thought, she tightens her grasp on her ID.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You ... You know Kumar?

Matilda: Hmm? Kumar? Who's that?

Matilda returns to their side with the files she found nearby.

Matilda: And what's with the shock? I thought we need to leave now.

She mumbles in confusion and picks up the last piece of paper on the ground.

Matilda: Okay, that's the last one! Let me see, Page 1, Page 2 ...

As she speaks, the files are flattened, moved around, and rearranged.

Matilda: Page 5, hmm?

She stops at a page with familiar content.

Matilda: What?

It is a data analysis chart. Some notes, hastily written in graceful handwriting, are left next to it. Some words are even highlighted with question marks.

Matilda: These papers are on celestial energy and exactly the one I want to practice on!

Matilda: That's right. The analysis on the arcane energy is very similar to that in the materials I found.

Matilda: But not completely. This one looks ...

The black curves in the chart make her stomach sink.

Her gaze slides down the page and fixes on a word with a question mark next to it.

Matilda: Ah! Manus Vindictae?

Matilda: What?!

3#4

The Heir

JMP-05

Kanjira: Burp. What a good meal.

Kanjira: Hmm? Still nothing happened after so long? She won't really be eaten by some monster, right?

Kanjira: Hmm. Forget it!

Kanjira: Lord whoever, bless that stupid moron has escaped from there. Oh, and without the treasures!

Kanjira wipes her mouth with the hem of her skirt and steps into the cave.

Kanjira: Be careful. Don't be spotted. Oh?

Kanjira: Huh! She's fine. What is she doing in the depths? Who are those two?

She quietly climbs on a rock nearby.

Kanjira: Oomph. Mmm!

Kanjira: I didn't know there were so many rocks here. Okay. Keep climbing, almost there.

She kicks her dusty feet in the air, struggling to climb onto a raised edge of the rock.

Kanjira: Huh?

Something grabs her ankle.

Kanjira: What is it?

She frowns and looks down ...

It is a severed hand.

Kanjira: AHHH!!

Impulsively, Kanjira kicks her leg.

The hand, already covered with many cracks, is thrown into the air and smashes into pieces on the ground.

Kanjira: Whuu ... phew ...

Is that a hand? Whose hand is it? Where does it come from?

Her heart beats violently.

She holds her breath and gathers enough courage to look closer.

Kanjira: It's stone?

She tentatively touches a lump with her fingertip. Nothing happens. Feeling relieved, she starts putting them back together.

Kanjira: ...!

Kanjira: It looks like one of those ugly statues in there, so they can move?

Kanjira: Wow!

Kanjira: It's just like, like the ...!

There's a twinkle of excitement in her eyes.

Kanjira: Like the story in the book!

Kanjira: Yes, that's right! Those "golems guarding the treasure."

Kanjira: They are true! I knew it! And "the dragon that eats the castle," "the gem that smashes the sea," "Open Sesame" ...

Kanjira: Ms. Sherjah is lying! They are not fairy tales!

Kanjira: No wonder she has two helpers. They are the "treasure hunters"! They beat the "guards"!

She nods at her thought, overjoyed by the conclusion.

Kanjira: Oh, yes! Just follow them secretly, and I will get at least a bit of the "treasure" they leave behind! Like how Kasim got the coin from the scales.

She is heartened by the plan.

She turns around, nimbly jumps on that rock again, and quietly follows the others in the cave.

Shamane: Okay, okay. I think I understood every Hindi word, but none of them make any sense anymore when put together.

In the messy cave, the three of them look at each other speechlessly. Shamane is patting himself on the head, trying to understand Kaalaa Baunaa's words one by one.

Shamane: You're saying, Kumar, that Kumar I know, the sister whom I've only seen once in my life ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: ... is also my tutor in the university.

Matilda: Plus, she's a bad guy associating with the Manus?!

Matilda slowly puts down the files.

Matilda: So these abnormal growth curves ... The fluctuation of celestial energy is a man-made result?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Actually, I'm not a hundred percent sure about their association, but yes, your conclusion about the growth curves is right.

Kaalaa Baunaa calmly takes over the files.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The fluctuation was caused by an unnamed celestial body, and its existence is only known to Kumar and me.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It was the object of our research at Banner University. At that time, we found some arcanum-related materials very helpful for our project, but then ...

She gently shakes her head.

Kaalaa Baunaa: She was way too radical. Arcanum is strictly prohibited in the field of human science, and we were expelled from the university. After that, our disagreement got even worse. In the end, we took different paths.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But apparently, neither of us gave up on the research. We could frequently feel the existence of each other from the changes of the celestial body.

Kaalaa Baunaa: And one day, I found an abnormality during the observation: the energy never fluctuated in such a fierce and peculiar way. I decided to contact her, but when I finally found the lab she had worked in, the staff told me she had already left.

She looks at Matilda.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Our common friend told me she had seen Kumar by coincidence. She saw her leave with the Manus.

Matilda: ...!

Kaalaa Baunaa spreads her fingers and shows Matilda a dusty stone in her left palm.

Despite the misshapen outline, the stone seems to be a little idol.

Kaalaa Baunaa: And I found this from what she left behind. I compared it to the hole in the wall. It does come from this cave, and it has something to do with the arcanum-related materials on that celestial body.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But Kumar never makes mistakes. This one is more like a clue she left to me.

Matilda: Hmm. I don't understand her.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Judging from the situation, apparently, I'm not the only one "invited."

She raises her right hand, showing them the wrinkled envelope.

There is a blue postmark on the envelope and an elephant pattern on the bright-yellow seal. Inside the envelope, there is a worn piece of paper with nothing on it.

Shamane: Oh, this is getting even stranger than seeing those moving statues!

Shamane: Like I said, I am, well, to be more precise, I "almost" am the last living member of my family.

Shamane points at the majestic elephant on the seal.

Shamane: This stamp was supposed to come from a special seal that belongs to the heir of the family. Unfortunately, it was passed down to me, and I lost it to a bear many years ago.

Shamane: I checked the postmark on the envelope and found the letter came from this remote cave, where even rock pigeons don't bother to pay a visit.

Shamane: Since it is highly unlikely that the bear with my seal in its belly would take transport all the way to a cave to send me a letter, I decided to come here myself and find out what this was all about.

Shamane: But there's one thing I found weird in what you said.

Shamane hesitates about what he is going to say.

Shamane: As far as I know, my sister is even worse than "unqualified," if taken as an arcanist—She's almost like a human! It's nearly impossible for her to use the most basic arcane skills!

Shamane: And this ...

He opens both of his palms and gestures in the direction of the broken statues on the ground.

Shamane: This is not something a random person from our world can do. Is she really able to control these things?

Kaalaa Baunaa: No, she can't.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But she has a solution—a solution even I'm not aware of. Theoretically, our skills can only create illusions and nothing more.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But if the Manus really offered to help her, even though I don't want to think this way, she may be able to do that.

Shamane: Oh, I forgot the Manus part.

Shamane: Alright. All I know is, if this letter is really an "invitation" from her, I guess this won't be a delightful trip for me.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I've heard about that incident in her family, and I don't think her ultimate purpose is just to gather us here.

She turns around and looks at Matilda with a serious but sincere expression.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Thank goodness I met you here, young lady. Can't believe I ran into a Foundation investigato- ...

Matilda: Ahem. Don't, don't mind the title! Every member of the Foundation is obliged to contribute to the cause of peace, let alone an arcanist as extraordinary as I am!

Kaalaa Baunaa: That's great. Sarasvati blessed me.

Matilda: Yeah, yeah, exactly. How fortunate the Foundation has been to have such an excellent subordinate like I am.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I hereby apply for assistance to the Foundation as an astronomy professor and an arcanist.

Matilda: Em, emm?

Matilda: Yes, Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Rather than find Kumar and the Manus, we have something more important to do now.

Matilda: Something more important?

Kaalaa Baunaa: We need the Foundation's assistance to evacuate the villagers and tourists in Mor Pankh village as soon as possible because that near-earth astero- ... No, no. It's not an asteroid.

Kaalaa Baunaa: That celestial body we study, not able to be observed by human technology, is approaching this village at a dangerous speed. It reaches level 5 on Torino Scale and 0.01 on Palermo Scale.

Matilda: What?

Kaalaa Baunaa: In brief, the meteor shower that is occurring during Dīpa Festival will become a disaster of meteorites. I tried to ask organizations in the surrounding areas for help, but this village is out of Chandigarh's jurisdiction.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Besides, the villagers refuse to accept help from any social organizations related to humans.

Shamane: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: The good news is, there are still days before the Dīpa Festival starts. We still have time to evacuate the people. Meanwhile, I will do whatever I can to find Kumar and stop her, no matter what her next step is.

Kaalaa Baunaa: If the Foundation offers its assistance, I will provide any support when needed.

Matilda: So this, this is her real ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Yes. In this case, what happened in the caves was probably nothing more than an experiment.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I'm not sure why she's doing this, but I won't allow such an abuse of our hard work.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It is our work, after all. That's why I must stop the star from falling.

Kanjira: ...!

Kanjira: D**n it.

Shamane: Hmm?

Shamane: Did you guys hear anything?

Kanjira: Hey!

The small figure vaults deftly over the wall, running down the road in the opposite direction.

Kanjira: Ugh. This is the worst, worst fairy tale ever!

Kanjira: It has no treasures, and now even rocks are falling down!

Kanjira: *pants* I, I have to go back.

Kanjira: And warn everyone!

She seems to know the place well. She takes a few turns, climbs over another wall, and lands in a deserted yard.

Kanjira: Run, run. Ajar, you need to take everyone to ...

Kanjira: *pants* I-I'm out of breath.

???: Kanjira?

Kanjira: Um, Ms. Sherjah?! Why, how you find this place?

Ms. Sherjah: Of course, I can find it. It's your secret base, right?

She reaches out and drags the nervous-looking girl to herself.

Ms. Sherjah: A secret base in other's house without the owner's permission? Well, well, well.

Kanjira: Aw. No, no, no, Ms. Sherjah. It's not time to judge me. Something huge just happen.

Ms. Sherjah: Sorry, sweet Jalebi. Your tricks never worked on me.

Sherjah catches the ear of the troublemaker.

Ms. Sherjah: Taught Ajar to steal? Broke into an old house? Let me check your pocket. I knew it! Whose wallet is this? Did you forget what I've taught you?

Kanjira: Ye-yes! I do all these! I'm sorry, Ms. Sherjah, but LET ME DOWN!! It's too late if we don't leave now! The village is going to destroy!!

Ms. Sherjah: What are you babbling about this time?

Kanjira: It's real, not lie! I even run all the way back from the shrine like idiot, and leave tuk tuk I borrow from Uncle Sinha there.

Ms. Sherjah: Ah! You went to the shrine and ate the offerings again! Young Miss!

Kanjira: *sobs* I'm really sorry! But you must believe me this time! Where are the others? Where they go? We must tell them now. They must take train and leave this place today.

Ms. Sherjah: *sighs* They went to the street for business. What on earth is happening?

Kanjira: Li- ... listen to me!

Kanjira stops, drawing a huge circle in the air with her hands.

Kanjira: I'm, I'm catch by a stone hand in the shrine's cave! And, and I see the "treasure hunters"! I hear what they say.

Kanjira: They say a big big stone called "meteorite" will fall and smash the village when Dīpa Festival start!

Ms. Sherjah: *sighs* Honey, I told you they are just fairy tales.

Kanjira: No! It's true! Those statues actually move.

Inside the old house, Kanjira is so busy persuading Sherjah that she has not noticed the approaching footsteps from outside the door.

Shamane: Ah, the lock's broken, but that's okay. I know the place well. Though Kumar hasn't come here very often in the past years, it's a good place to start with, at least better than randomly searching like a headless chicken.

Kanjira: ...!

Matilda: ...

Ms. Sherjah: You are ...?

The two groups look at each other in silence through the door.

As the silence goes on, Matilda notices the wallet in Sherjah's hand.

Matilda: Hey!

Matilda: That in your hand ... Is that my wallet?

3#5

Noises from the Stone Cellar

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An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

The Sacred Fig

JMP-06

Old House

Crowded by these many people, the old house seems even shabbier.

The five of them sit around a piece of furniture that can barely be used as a table. The awkwardness surrounds them like a naughty bird.

Ms. Sherjah: Thank you so much for your understanding, Mr. Sharma and Ms. Bouanich.

Shamane: Ah, please, Madam. You have my admiration for voluntarily taking care of these kids. Besides, technically speaking, this room doesn't belong to me anymore ...

Shamane: ... but to my sister, Kumar. I wish I could leave the house to you for future use.

He gestures for Kaalaa Baunaa.

Shamane: But you heard what the lady said—I don't even know if the house will survive the meteor.

This is probably not the best time for a sense of humor. Everyone in the room falls into silence. The coming crisis makes them heavy in mind.

They sit on the dusted ground. Shamane magically takes out several ceramic cups from his luggage.

Shamane: This is the latest batch of Darjeeling tea. Some locals gave it to me when I went across their village. Ah, careful. It's hot.

He touches a cup to feel its temperature and passes out the cups one by one.

Matilda snatches Kanjira's cup angrily.

Matilda: You two are in it together? You've been lying to me all this time?!

Kanjira: Hey, quiet before Ms. Sherjah.

Kanjira: You don't lose anything, my lady. Please forgive me, will you? Now pass me cookies! I need fill my belly and get to work!

Kaalaa Baunaa: My apologies, Ms. Sherjah. I know this is totally out of the blue.

Kaalaa Baunaa takes out her files again. She has carefully prepared herself to persuade the others.

Kaalaa Baunaa: And the details are yet to be verified, but our valuable time is running out. The last thing we should do is keep on waiting.

Ms. Sherjah: Emm.

Her gaze sweeps the difficult and obscure data and words.

Ms. Sherjah: Kaalaa Baunaa.

Her face suddenly brightens up.

Ms. Sherjah: My! I think I know this name! I've read the paper co-authored by you and Professor Himani.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Huh? You've read my paper?

Ms. Sherjah: Emm, yeah! I'm studying in a public university in Chandigarh. I get to learn a lot of new stuff there.

Ms. Sherjah: I had a whim to study astronomy before, and I remember reading it in a periodical.

She gesticulates at the papers.

Ms. Sherjah: Yes, I'm sure it's the same name.

Ms. Sherjah: This part and this part! I've read them in your paper, but emm, this one on the side, I don't know anything like it.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's okay. That one involves the knowledge of arcanum.

Kaalaa Baunaa relaxes a bit.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Anyway, this is good news—no, great news. So what are you doing in Mor Pankh?

Ms. Sherjah: Oh, I take care of the kids here in my spare time. Most of them are humans, but there are arcanists, too.

Kanjira: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: I see.

Ms. Sherjah: So, what are you going to do now?

Her question contains both confusion and worry.

Ms. Sherjah: I know the top priority is to evacuate the villagers, but we don't have much time since the Dīpa Festival will start in less than four days. Besides, things are complicated in this village.

She frowns at the thought. This could be tricky.

Ms. Sherjah: Most of them, including me, had moved to Chandigarh.

Ms. Sherjah: And the rest of them ... *sighs*

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: I've heard about that on the way here.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Most villagers are reluctant to leave, no matter what I say. I tried by starting with those young arcanists, but shame! It didn't work at all.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The silver lining is, we have the helping hand of Ms. Bouanich. She will try to make contact with the Foundation as soon as possible. But we still need to evacuate every villager we can.

Ms. Sherjah: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: We know almost nothing about Kumar's plan now, not to mention her whereabouts or purpose.

The ice has been broken between them, but their moods have not yet lightened.

Shamane: Relax. For now, we have two solutions to the problem.

Shamane raises both of his hands, palms up.

Shamane: First, let's find my clever, evil sister so that our astronomer friend can figure out a way to stop the meteor. Or, spread the word and tell everyone to take the earliest train and leave the impact area!

Shamane: It's hard to be optimistic given the situation, but at least there is something we can do to reduce the damage.

Shamane: But if we continue to sit around waiting, the situation will only worsen. Come, let's think.

Bushes and weeds grow throughout the yard. Matilda finds a relatively open area, taking out a silver device from her pocket with great caution.

Sherjah and Kanjira, the two people who are most familiar with the village, have set out to evacuate the villagers. Inside the house, Shamane and Kaalaa Baunaa are turning the room into a cloud of dust to find any possible clues about Kumar.

The only quiet place left for Matilda to perform her duty as "Foundation investigator" is this long-deserted yard.

Matilda: Great! It finally comes in handy.

SPF-I: SPF-I Portable Contact Device activated. Welcome.

SPF-I: Arcane skill verification activated. Please make sure you are not equipped with any wands. Read out the random incantation displayed on the screen clearly. Make sure your tone remains stable.

Matilda: Ahem, Fuego Burn.

SPF-I: Verification success. Registered user: Matilda Bouanich. Access level: D.

SPF-I: No abnormal arcane skill fluctuation detected in the area so far. Level D access only supports Quick Report.

Matilda: Hmm? Insufficient access?! The description says ... Ah, so only an investigator can request backup through this system.

Matilda: So what's the point of carrying it around all along? I thought it would be useful for emergencies.

Matilda: No. Does this mean I will miss the opportunity to study the celestial energy, plus blow my chance to capture the Manus?

Matilda: The reception is terrible here. How am I going to get in touch with the Foundation!

Shamane: Oh, that doesn't sound like any progress with her.

Shamane: And what I have here is only books! Books and books and books. Nothing else!

Shamane: "Calf Feeding and Management" ... Is my sister really an astronomer? Was I mistaken about anything?

Shamane: Hey, Matilda! If you like, there should be the last two pieces of Plera-J on the table! Remember to have them with tea, or it's going to hurt your throat and ruin your beautiful voice.

Shamane: Kanjira was ecstatic about those cookies. She even took three pieces with her when she left. *sighs* I hope that kind human girl will get to the train station safely with those kids.

Shamane: Now, let's take a look at you. What are you doing?

Shamane: Is this the stone Kumar left to you?

Kaalaa Baunaa carefully parts the stone. An idol emerges from it.

Shamane: Vishnu?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Brahma creates, Shiva exterminates, and Vishnu safeguards the balance of the world, lying on the Ocean of Stars.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: According to the materials ... Well, maybe I should explain it with mythologies for non-researchers.

Kaalaa Baunaa: They mentioned three idols, but Vishnu's is the only one left, so she must have taken the other two. Perhaps it's proof that Kumar abandoned the path of maintaining the balance in the first place.

Kaalaa Baunaa: That mural there ... She said the mythology on it has been passed down in her family.

Shamane: *sighs* That's true. I've recited that story at least 20 times, but the part on the mural, to be honest, it feels so out of place to me.

Shamane: It was more like foisted into those well-known myths, like, emm, a pair of ox horns on a horse's head.

The comparison brings a smile to Kaalaa Baunaa's face. But she shakes her head.

Kaalaa Baunaa: An unusual metaphor. But actually, it plays a significant part in connecting all the mythologies we know.

Kaalaa Baunaa: These mythologies are the primary material of our research. We've been trying to prove human science with basic arcanum theory.

Kaalaa Baunaa: In fact, there is a connection between them, and they can support each other.

She sighs.

Kaalaa Baunaa: If arcanists and humans could get along, I suppose the world would have developed faster than it does now.

Sensing Shamane's confusion, Kaalaa Baunaa pauses to reorganize her language.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's not easy to explain it through, but in short, there is another universe in the shape of an egg affecting reality. We call it the Meditator's Realm.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Just like our daily dreams, you can enter it once you fall asleep, but that's not how we do it. We connect part of our Gnosis with the Realm through a special kind of meditation.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's not as easy as it sounds. One needs to either master the meditation skills like we do or use a special medium as an anchor.

She raises her hand, showing the Vishnu idol to them.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Some mythologies are the original translation of the Realm. An existence that cannot be observed through the methods in this world can be located as long as it is included in mythology. That's how we located that star.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Sadly, if we can't prove its existence with data recorded by human technology, our discovery is useless.

Shamane: I'm surprised. For all this time, she has never given up on studying the old arcanum tale of our family.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You can even say she's fanatic about it. It's just ...

Kaalaa Baunaa frowns.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Indeed, we can do a lot of supernatural things in the Realm. If your mind is calm or your anchor is strong enough, you can even do whatever you want. But it's limited inside there.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Remember I said it's like our daily dreams? Just think of it as a controllable one. Everything in the Realm is created based on reality. In other words, it's nothing but a "mirror," and the images in a mirror can never affect reality.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's impossible to bring anything into the Realm, not to mention taking anything out.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But the statues in the cave actually exist in this world. They are tangible.

Kaalaa Baunaa: That means she's gone much further than I do. She mastered a method I'm not aware of. What bewilders me is her arcane skill. How did she do that if not for the Manus's help?

Shamane: Oh, c'mon, she also knows that cave a lot better than I do, right?

Shamane goes to the book pile on the other side of the room and casually opens the Underground Survival Guide on top.

Shamane: We never hung out much. How long did she stay in the village on her last visit? A month maybe, or two weeks? I'm not sure. I even crushed her glasses by accidentally sitting on them. Those are the same glasses you have on your belt.

Shamane: At that time, I thought she was a distant relative I don't know of. After all, it's rare to meet someone so clever and open-minded in this village. I even lent this room to her. *sighs* This was my secret basement, you know!

Shamane: But only after we parted did my father tell me that she's my sister—the daughter they sent away for lack of arcanum talent!

Kaalaa Baunaa: I do remember those days roughly. Back then, I couldn't find her in the institution. I was all alone for a long time.

Shamane: What happened to her has inevitably affected me. I grew more and more rebellious against the family rules.

Shamane: It's like a story full of cliches: giving up the training, refusing to listen to my father, skipping all the practice I could possibly avoid. I didn't want to be the blockhead hedged by the so-called "family heritage"!

Shamane: Of course, at the end of the story, I paid my price for breaking away.

He raises the rough prosthesis and stops turning the pages.

Shamane: But I think, for her, it is even harder to break free.

He gently takes out a photo from the book.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Shamane: I guess her plan is to "invite" me over to this dump full of bad memories, and "Swoosh ... BOOM!" Smash all the annoyances with a star.

Shamane: Hmm. That's a solemn ending! Pity the ones she hates are all gone now.

Kaalaa Baunaa takes the photo from him.

Shamane: But, how come you're invited, too? Did you upset her as well?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Hmm. That's a good point. Hatred could be the most likely reason.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Actually, we didn't get along well after we left the university.

Kaalaa Baunaa touches the girl in the photo with her fingertip.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Ever since our identities as arcanists were exposed, we couldn't stay in the institution anymore. That's also the beginning of our disagreement.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I always thought that, on the way to proving myself, ourselves, we were each other's only friend and best partner. How could I finish my study in campus full of humans without her?

The small idol in her palm is a bit cool to the touch.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But then my mind was changed.

Her voice lowers.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I wouldn't have connected Kumar with Manus Vindictae, if Himani's words were all I heard.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But I know that was not the first time they made contact.

Shamane: You mean ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Yes. I don't know the reason, but the Manus has contacted her long ago. She gave them the cold shoulder at the time, but I knew something inside her had changed.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Soon after that, she left me, taking all the materials with her.

Shamane: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: I know the only thing I can do to meet her again is keep walking on the way to study that celestial body. That will lead me to her one day.

Kaalaa Baunaa: As I said, we could frequently feel the existence of each other from the changes of the celestial body, but she could always find more information than I do, because the traces left by arcanum are more obvious than those left by science.

Kaalaa Baunaa: This connection between us conveyed my belief to her that one day we would meet again as colleagues.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I just didn't expect that this would be the final outcome of my observation ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: ... or that we would end up on the opposite sides.

Shamane: Emm.

Shamane: Can there be any lamer stories to tell than these two?

Kaalaa Baunaa: For now, we can't find more clues in her house. Maybe we should go to the shrine again? How much do you remember the myth of your family? As I just said, that was the primary material of our study.

Matilda: Ah-ha! A geeenius you are, Matilda!

Shamane: Hahaha, running and jumping around with hot tea. I sure know the fun within.

Shamane: But at my age, with the benefit of hindsight, I have to tell you to be careful. You might get burned by the tea.

Matilda: No, no! It's the spice! The spice in the tea!

Shamane: More spice to it? Hmm. I do have a dozen kinds of different spices with me. Looks like you are very used to them in tea.

Matilda: Exactly, these spices!

Matilda pats herself on the chest proudly.

Matilda: Now it's time for Matilda to show you her best shot!

Matilda: The orb, cumin ... Oh! You also have clove blossom here! Fantastic.

Kaalaa Baunaa picks up a transparent blue crystal to look at it.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The crystal divination. I've spent too much time in the human world to remember the convenience of arcanum.

Matilda: If I can foresee any sign about Kumar, our problem will be ended!

Matilda: With the help of the great Matilda, of course!

Matilda: Hmm, okay, take a deep breath, give me your hands, rest them on top of mine. Yes, like that.

Matilda: Now, think of Kumar in your head.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Shamane: ...

Matilda: ...?

Matilda: Odd ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...!

Shamane: ...?

Matilda: What, what is this? Is that the train station?

Instead of showing the sign as usual, the fog in the orb grows unexpectedly. It surges and gathers into a mass of black slime.

Matilda: ...!

Matilda: There are ...

Matilda snaps open her eyes.

Matilda: The Manus already reached Mor Pankh?!

3#6

The Silver Bangle

JMP-07

Kanjira: Hurry up, Ajar! Bring those guys, too! Take the tuk tuk to the train station. Here are a few spots in my caravan!

Ajar: Yes, Boss!

Kanjira: No, wait. Where's Sherjah! What took her so long? Wasn't she with you?

Ajar: She ... I saw her went to the other side of the village.

Kanjira: Over there? I remember that's ...

Kanjira: Tsk!

Ms. Sherjah: Sir, please, please trust me.

She wobbles her head while begging with sincerity.

Ms. Sherjah: You have to convince your father. It's not like before.

Rajesh: *sighs* Sherjah, it's not that I don't want to talk to my father.

He bends over to place the candle before the stairs, lining it up neatly with the other candles.

Rajesh: You have come to me ... I don't know, so many times. Father has already scolded me several times for letting Jina learn all those unorthodox stuff from you.

Rajesh: You know, those human books ...

His eyebrows furrow, and his face grows red with anger.

Rajesh: You can see, even Jina's mother has no help in the kitchen now. I even have to prepare the candles for Dīpa Festival myself!

Rajesh: No matter what you say, I'm not taking your advice this time. You'd better leave before my father comes out. You know how mad he gets when he sees a human.

Takal: Hey Rajesh, who are you talking to? You, you again?!

Ms. Sherjah: Sir, please listen to me. It's an emergency. I can't tell you the details now, but in a word, this village is going to be destroyed by meteorites! You and your family need to leave here now.

Takal: Enough! You've played that trick a dozen times. We know what you are up to! Trying to get us out of this place? No way!

Rajesh: Please, Father. You know Sherjah has been ...

Takal: I am talking to her! Leave now, or I'll ...

The old man snatches the broom from next to the door.

No one pays attention to the running steps coming from afar.

Kanjira: Punji! Stop him!

Punji: Hiss!

Takal: Oh, oh, ah! Who are you, kid? Why ... why are you on human's side?

Ms. Sherjah: Kanjira!

Kanjira: What, who else should I help if not her? You? An ungrateful old pig?

Kanjira squeezes in between them and confronts the old villager, like an upright snake ready to attack.

Takal: You ...

Kanjira: How many times has Sherjah helped you, and how many things did Jina learn from her? You! You only know being mean to her and talking about something like arcanists and humans!

Kanjira: Stay if you like! Sherjah is being so nice and saving your life, but no one is clever enough to listen! Better let the star fall on you and crush you into ashes!

Kanjira: Let's go!

Ms. Sherjah: I'm so sorry. She ...

Ms. Sherjah: Aah!

Without saying another word, Kanjira seizes Sherjah's arm and drags her away.

Ms. Sherjah: Kanjira, stop! Don't pull me! It hurts.

Kanjira makes a sudden stop. Her chest is pumping up and down out of anger.

Kanjira: They is always mean to you and bullying you! Why you must look for trouble?

Ms. Sherjah: Kanjira ...

Kanjira: After all the things you do for them, how can they treat you like that?! Just leave them alone! Come with me. I still have your spot on my caravan.

Kanjira: The time for entering and exiting the trains of the station is the same every day! I remember it well. There will be a train leaving here soon. There is still time.

Ms. Sherjah: ...

Ms. Sherjah: Kanjira, take a deep breath and listen to me.

Sherjah becomes conscious of her student's emotions. She bends down to the level of Kanjira's eyes, shaking her arms to reassure her.

Kanjira: ...

Ms. Sherjah: I know you said all those things to them for me, and I appreciate that.

Ms. Sherjah: But think about it, if I treat them just the same way they treated me, just stand by and watch them head to death ...

Sherjah chooses her words carefully, as patient as she used to be in every English class.

Ms. Sherjah: Even if I'm doing this out of understandable fury, how would it make me any different to them?

Kanjira: ...!

Ms. Sherjah: Volunteering to help you, and, in your opinion, "risking my life to save them" ... They are all out of my own will.

Ms. Sherjah: Hatred doesn't end itself, Kanjira. It has to be ended by someone.

Kanjira stares at her teacher's face in confusion. Slowly, she lowers her eyes and looks down at her feet.

Kanjira: I, I don't understand.

Kanjira: Do I ... Do we mean nothing to you?

Ms. Sherjah: How come?! What gave you such an idea? You are my most precious children. All of you are my treasures!

Kanjira: This is not the first time you prefer they over we.

Kanjira: You always put they first when there's a problem.

She knows well that Sherjah should not be blamed for this.

But this doesn't relieve her of the bitterness.

Ms. Sherjah: ...

Ms. Sherjah: Kanjira ...

Kanjira: I, I am not able to read, but I'm not a kid now. If I can, I don't want to be an arcanist too, so me, you, and Ajar is the same.

They have no time for this.

Kanjira struggles to choke back the tears.

But she's overwhelmed by the fear of losing Sherjah.

Ms. Sherjah: Kanjira. Don't cry, Kanjira.

Ms. Sherjah: So you've been thinking ... Oh, little one. You're just like us! We are your family!

Kanjira: No, you don't understand, Ms. Sherjah. Enough talk. Maybe I don't understand any of your lectures, but you can't stay here!

Ms. Sherjah: ...

Ms. Sherjah: I'm sorry, Kanjira.

Sherjah has never found it so difficult to refuse someone.

Ms. Sherjah: I have to admit they're unreasonable, but as I said, we should put that aside now. It's a matter of life, Kanjira. I can't ...

Kanjira: ...

Kanjira feels her stomach churning due to the bitterness, urging her to act on impulse.

Kanjira: You ... you is not listening to me at all!

Kanjira: Fine! Be a savior and go! We'll leave here on our own!

Ms. Sherjah: Kanjira!

Sherjah's hand only lands on empty air. Kanjira runs away and disappears from her sight.

Kanjira: *sobbing*

She leans on the steering wheel, sobbing.

Kanjira: I, I'm never talking to her again!

The caravan stops at the train station, which seems out of place in the small village.

Kanjira: Ajar! Uncle Sinha!

Kanjira: Hmm. Where are they? Why is here so quiet? It was crowded this morning.

ooze

Kanjira: This, this is ...

Manus Disciple: UGGGHHHH!

Kanjira: ...!

Kanjira: Blood, so much blood ...

The terrifying masked monsters are staggering among the stone pillars in the train station.

Kanjira: No! Ajar!! Uncle Sinha!!

Ajar: Hey! Boss! Over here. It's safer here. Come over!

A smart head pokes out from behind the pillar.

Kanjira: ...!

She quickly sneaks through the station on tiptoe without being noticed.

Kanjira: Whoa, I was almost scared to death! Good to see you safe. What happened here?

Ajar: No idea! A bunch of dreadful people suddenly showed up. Each of them has a mask on their face. Over there, on the platform. There are a few more!

Ajar: They came out of nowhere and attacked the passengers for no reason.

Ajar seems to be thinking of something. He can't help but shiver.

Ajar: But luckily, the villagers had been evacuated before they came. Thanks to Ms. Sherjah's efforts.

Kanjira: ...

Ajar: We were left behind because we had to wait for you. Did you come here on your own? Where's Ms. Sherjah?

Kanjira: She ...

Ajar: Quiet. They're coming!

Ajar: Don't, don't let them see you.

As he shrinks in fear, something drops out of his pocket.

Ajar: Ah! D**n, my silver ...

Tonk.

A silver bracelet bounces briskly on the floor.

The slight noise is thundering in the quiet station.

Kanjira: Really?! You have to take those goods with you now?!

Manus Disciple: AAARRRHHHH!

Kanjira: RUN!!

Manus Disciple: EEERRRHHHH!

Kanjira: Ajar, watch out!! Ah!

Ajar: Boss!

A sharp rune grazes Kanjira's shoulder, leaving a deep wound.

Kanjira: Ah ...! It hurts so much! Punji, bite them!

Punji: Sssss!

Kanjira: Go hide in the caravan! I can handle this. Ah!

Another rune flashes across her ankle. Kanjira loses her balance and falls to the ground.

Kanjira: Ah! It hurts.

Kanjira: Oh, no, I'm dead for sure.

Matilda: Pafisto Pecise!

Kanjira: Hmm?

As Kanjira looks up, the first thing that comes to her tearful, blurry sight is a head with milky blonde hair.

Matilda: *pants* Phew! So glad I caught up in time.

Kaalaa Baunaa: There are people over here! Let's take her first.

Shamane: This place is soon going to be dangerous. I know a place. It's close to here. Come, take them this way!

Manus Disciple: UGGGHHHH!

Matilda: Humph, you dirty, filthy, less-than-elegant mugs! Matilda won't even sweat bringing you down!

Matilda: May the peace be with us!

3#1

Drown in Tears

JMP-08

Courtyard of the Sharma Old House

Kanjira: Ah, ouch. Is your medic skill really okay?

Matilda: Hah? Are you questioning my skill? I was always, for most of the time, the best student in first aid class! There, the pain is gone, yeah?

Kanjira: Well, hmm, not bad.

Matilda: Hey, I'm not done with your stealing!

Matilda pats her on the wound to show her discontent.

Kanjira: Hey, hey, hey. Ah! I already apologize!

Matilda: Humph, slick!

Matilda turns her eyes toward the two people standing under the tree.

Matilda: Hmm. I didn't expect to see this.

Matilda: What a spacious yard for a house located right next to the train station!

A massive sacred fig stands in the middle of the yard.

It looks a lot older than it was in the photo, and it has become leafless, like a skeleton.

Shamane: Old buddy, I'm surprised that you're still here.

His rough hands land on the equally rough bark. The tree responds with nearly imperceptible cracks.

Kaalaa Baunaa: We have settled everyone so far. I didn't expect so many Manus members here.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I've never encountered them before. They can't be communicated with. How horrible!

She's still haunted by the battle.

Kaalaa Baunaa: And, since we meet them here, it means ...

Shamane: Kumar did cooperate with the Manus.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Ugh!

Kaalaa Baunaa: Shoot! It's completely out of control.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The incantation in the cave—She must be able to detect the fluctuation caused by it, and that gave us away.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But what in the world is her purpose?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Did she think I would stop her? So she deployed these things to slaughter the village?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Does revenge matter that much to her?

Kaalaa Baunaa feels everything is so absurd.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I trusted her. I never believed she would do such a thing, even if we're no longer on the same path.

Shamane: ...

Vishnu's idol feels particularly hard in Kaalaa Baunaa's soft palm.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But the reality tells me, my trust in her is nothing but a joke.

Shamane: Hatred changes people.

Shamane shakes his head.

Shamane: It's not a choice, Kaalaa Baunaa. You don't have to feel bad for trusting people. You trust someone because they are trustworthy, but you never need a reason to hate.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Shamane: Let your guard down for even one second, the toxic idea will sneak into your mind, and it would be impossible to get rid of it.

Shamane: It will burn your mind and sanity, until you become an animal living for revenge, even forget your own name.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Shamane: ...

Shamane: Oh, don't look at me like that. It's nothing personal! In my mind, she is still my cool and scholarly sister. I was young and easily fooled back then.

Shamane: What I said was based on my real-life experience. I was way more outrageous than her!

Shamane: Ah, I mean, we were all young once, right?

Kaalaa Baunaa shakes her head and sighs.

Kaalaa Baunaa: No matter what, she is already on the move. But we don't even know where she is.

While Kaalaa Baunaa and Shamane are talking quietly, in the other corner of the yard, a heated quarrel is taking place between the girls.

Matilda: Don't even think about it! The painkiller won't last long. There's no way you can drive with a wounded foot!

As soon as Kanjira stands up, Matilda pushes her back to the seat.

Kanjira: But Sherjah is still out there! She can't use any arcane skills. If she's find by the mask monster ...

Matilda: Even, even if you are right on this, I can't just let you ... Hmm?

SPF-I: SPF-I Portable Contact Device activated. Abnormal arcane skill fluctuation detected. Conducting analysis.

Matilda: It just activates itself, eh?

SPF-I: Source of abnormal arcane skill fluctuation confirmed. Similar faction: Manus Vindictae. Margin of error: 0.121%. Emergency support application sent.

SPF-I: Adjusted support application priority to: HIGH.

Matilda: Does it mean we can ask the Foundation for backup now?

Matilda: This is great! People, I finally got in touch with the Foundation!

Shamane: Yeah? That's good news!

Kaalaa Baunaa: But the Manus is still wandering out there.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Before the Foundation evacuates them, the village will be destroyed.

Kaalaa Baunaa: We can't just sit around and watch.

Kaalaa Baunaa looks down at the glasses. Her finger gently swipes across the broken temple.

Kaalaa Baunaa: There is another way.

She speaks up, though hesitantly, after the long silence.

Matilda: Way? What way?

Kaalaa Baunaa: If she can do it, I can do it, too.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Maybe I can find traces of her if I enter the Realm.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Because I also mastered meditation skills.

Kaalaa Baunaa's eyes fix on a stone. She's lost in her thoughts.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Yes, that's right. I know the path inside.

Kaalaa Baunaa: What do I need? Yes, water, enough water to soak me in.

Her eyes can't help but move to the large ceramic vat in the corner.

Matilda: Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa?

Shamane: ...

Shamane: Now, hold on. Please wait.

Shamane waves his hand in front of the researcher, who is already carried away by some emotion.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...?

Shamane: If it was so easy, why don't you look for her in the Realm in the first place?

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...!

Kaalaa Baunaa: I ...

Shamane: It is a risky move. Am I right?

Kaalaa Baunaa: How did you know?

Shamane: Oh, just my instincts, or experiences, perhaps.

He gives her a gentle wave of his hand.

Shamane: No offense, but when I look at you, I see a desperate tiger cub cornered by the hunters.

Shamane: The situation is not as simple as you think.

Shamane: Since she can "invite" us to Mor Pankh, she can play the same trick and "invite" you to her Realm.

Shamane: This could be a trap, a trap to keep you stuck inside the Realm.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: You are right. It is a risky move.

Kaalaa Baunaa: With the other two idols as her anchors, she is the true dominator of the Realm now.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I can't foresee what's ahead of us in there, so I've been avoiding it.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But ...

Kaalaa Baunaa looks up at him.

Kaalaa Baunaa: We don't have other choices, do we?

Shamane: Whoa. Now we are talking, you seem ready.

Shamane: But, hmm ...

He shakes his head with slight disapproval.

Shamane: Whatever you decide to do next, don't. This is the advice from an experienced hunter.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Why?

Shamane: Because whatever is in your mind now is going to send you into the hunter's trap. This happens to all kinds of animals. When the animal realizes it is cornered, its mind will be in a muddle.

Shamane: It can't think of anything else, but at the same time, it strangely grows overconfident. It will take the gamble of escaping from its last way out, which is also going to be the entrance of the trap.

Shamane: Trust me.

He seems unusually serious.

Shamane: I know how you feel. You thought there's no way out but a footlog bridge.

She stares at his face for a long time. Eventually, she shakes her head.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The Manus followers are still wandering about, and some villagers haven't been moved to safer locations.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But sometimes, we must take the risky path to get out of the dreadful situation, even though it is full of traps.

Shamane: ...

He notices her fingers clutch and loosen repeatedly out of anxiety.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It may not solve all the problems, but it's better than doing nothing.

Kaalaa Baunaa: If this really is a trap, that means we will meet again.

Kaalaa Baunaa: And I have been waiting for a chance to talk to her face-to-face for too long.

Shamane: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: I have been chasing after an imaginary goal since she left me.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I watched that star closely, taking down everything that I could observe. However, despite all the efforts, deep down, I know better than anyone else—it's useless.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I remember those days, almost half of which were like living in a mist. But now ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: But now, I can feel it. Her silhouette is right there in front of me.

Kaalaa Baunaa: To be honest, this is not the best time to "seize this chance."

Matilda: Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But no matter how I look at it, this is too good an opportunity to pass up.

Shamane: ...

Shamane meets her gaze squarely.

Then he blinks. He scratches his head, feeling a bit powerless.

Shamane: Emm. Okay. Fine. *sighs*

Shamane: If you insist on doing this, I will not stop you.

Shamane: We all have our lessons to learn. And you are right—we don't have any better options.

Shamane: What is it they say? No risk, no feast, huh?

Shamane: But please keep this in mind—no matter what happens, your safety will always be the top priority.

Shamane: We cannot bear to lose someone who is capable of putting this to an end.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I will.

3#8

The Little Guardians · 1/2

JMP-09

They gather before the ceramic vat in the yard.

Shamane: Are you sure? To use this?

Kaalaa Baunaa: What's wrong with it? It has enough water to soak me in.

Shamane looks at the old vat and then checks the filthy water and rotten leaves inside. There is a silence between them.

Shamane: Hmm, you are much more practical than I thought.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Oh, before I go ...

She hands the Vishnu idol to Matilda.

Matilda: Hmm? Aren't you going to take it with you, Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa?

Kaalaa Baunaa: No.

She slowly shakes her head.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Shamane has a point. This is our last chance to win this fight, and it should be kept away from Kumar as far as possible.

Matilda: Emm.

Matilda: Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa, take this with you then!

Matilda passes over a crystal. It is shining brightly, like a freshly picked star.

Kaalaa Baunaa: This is your ...

Matilda: My pendulum! It's one of my collections, one of the purest! Even I don't have a lot of them around.

Matilda: I realized that the theory of meditation you've talked about is quite similar to some of the crystal divination theories. So, perhaps this will help you in the water, if the crystal can stabilize the magnetic field and guide you in there.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You ...

Matilda: Humph, no need to be surprised. This is how quickly a genius can think!

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Thank you.

Shamane: Ah, great. So, it's only me who can't understand this "meditation in water" thing. Well, it takes all sorts of rocks to form a mountain.

Before he finishes his sentence, Kaalaa Baunaa has quickly submerged her legs in the water, as if the cold didn't bother her at all.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Okay, the pendulum and enough liquid.

Kaalaa Baunaa: And all I have to do now is ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Think of Kumar.

She bends her knees and lets herself slide into the water.

Her world is immediately free of sounds.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

As soon as her head is completely submerged in water, the cold attacks from all directions.

Kaalaa Baunaa: *inhales*

Be it real or false, delusional or real, a world reappears before her.

???

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Where else could it be more suitable ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: ... than the place we first met?

The familiar stone stairs extend much longer than she remembers. The rough red bricks, the well-calculated and carefully designed arc ... Everything in Jantar Mantar has a unique kind of beauty.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Hah. How thoughtful you were, Kumar ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: ... to recreate the observatory in the Realm.

The figure standing still on its top looks like a black singularity.

She knows who it is.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Just an illusion in my mind.

Now, her left foot is on the first step.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...!

Resistance is expected.

Kaalaa Baunaa: She remembered almost every detail of me as a child.

The figure standing in front of her greatly resembles her younger self—always fist-clenching, always ready for confrontation.

And now "the girl" is irritated by the intrusion.

Illusion: ...!

"She" rushes toward Kaalaa Baunaa and throws quick punches.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Oh, it hurts!

Kaalaa Baunaa: Did it hurt this much when I hit someone as a child?

Illusion: Get out! You should not be here!

"She" tries to drive Kaalaa Baunaa away, fighting her like a trained warrior.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Ah, yes. Mom had taught me a few moves to deal with those brats at that age.

Illusion: Leave!

Kaalaa Baunaa: Hmm. This feels weird.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Did Kumar put you here? To guard this fragment of memory?

Illusion: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: This shall be the obstacle in my way to where I want to be.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's time to face the illusion from the past.

The sun rises and the moon veils its face. Life's gentle fingers guide each tender seedling, a hint of a different path free of monotony.
小径

Fight of the bulldogs

Venus shines. Thoughts flow easily from your lips into your pen. The wellspring of Creation shall gush unabated.
小径

Fight of the bulldogs

Jupiter falls silent. Light a lamp in your attic and allow your boundless imagination to wander.
小径

Fight of the bulldogs

Mercury is in retrograde. A projector that plays on its own, the predictions that issue forth uninvited. Any desire for reticence must be stymied.
小径

Fight of the bulldogs

The Moon hangs high in the sky, the Sun in its thrall. Heaven and Earth have joined hands again, as they did when the world was born.
小径

Fight of the bulldogs

The Other Mountain Boulder

小径

An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

The Little Guardians · 2/2

JMP-09

Illusion: Ah!

The illusion is dispersed and then gathers again in the distance, but this time, "she" is no longer irritated.

Illusion: Heh heh.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...!

"She" gradually fades away in the light and shadow of the observatory, and her voice goes further and further.

Illusion: From the past, to the present, and the future.

Illusion: The thing you are clinging on to, facing, and chasing ... Think what it is.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa lowers her head to look at her palm.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You are still asking questions that cannot be answered, just as you always did.

Kaalaa Baunaa: What do you think I "should" chase after?

Her fingers clench gently.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I won't be misled this time, Kumar.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I have never given up studying astronomy since that day.

There is only an echo in the empty space. The illusion has gone.

She looks up at the almost endless stairs.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Keep moving.

3#8

Outside the Fence

JMP-10

Kaalaa Baunaa: Whuu ... phew ...

First, the child self, then the teenage self, and then the young adult self. Only in the Meditator's Realm can one face so many past selves ...

... and defeat them one after another.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The 20-year-old me was fierce.

Kaalaa Baunaa rubs her bruised cheeks.

Kaalaa Baunaa: *hiss* That pain feels real.

Kumar: You came here sooner than I expected, Kaalaa Baunaa.

The wind feels like tingling knives on the rooftop. A familiar, if not too familiar, figure once again emerges in front of her.

Kumar: I knew you would come.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kumar.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Finally. See you again.

Kumar: I miss you dearly, too, my child. I hope you've been doing well while I was away.

Kumar: Hope you're happy with the surroundings I set. I always find it enjoyable here—a place full of memories and perfect for small talks.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I'd rather you suffered, Miss.

Kumar: Ah, someone is having a worse attitude these days.

Kaalaa Baunaa looks around to observe the surroundings.

Kumar: There's no need to look around, kid. I already had a few years of experience in the field before you started your research. And one of the most basic skills one has to master in the Meditator's Realm is to cover up the traces of reality.

The sky is dark, like the surface of dusted glassware.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Even so, you didn't even think about creating a starry sky for yourself here.

Kumar is silent for a moment and then shakes her head.

Kumar: Hmm. That would be unnecessary. You can see it any time outside this Realm if you like.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Why did you "invite" me here?

Kumar: ...

Kumar: I know you've put in a lot of efforts. I understand the difficulty within and sympathize with you, Kaalaa Baunaa. I always do, just like what I did with my younger brother. By the way, that letter has been delivered to him safely, I assume?

Kumar: You're smart enough not to bring the Vishnu statue with you. Did somebody kindly remind you not to do that?

Kumar: Never mind. That's not helpful.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I don't understand. Why involve him?

Behind Kumar, an old finderscope is aiming at the sky.

Kumar: Emm, maybe I was being vindictive out of "hatred," like you said.

Kumar: After all, they precluded me from doing anything even before I gave it a try. Although my misfortune was not my brother's doing, there's no one else left in the family to take my anger.

Kumar: So ask me now. Ask me anything you wish to know. I can tell you everything. What you're curious about, what you're confused about, anything you can't work out in your little brain. I can explain it all.

She smiles warmly, but her words are as cold as usual.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Hasn't the idea that I might locate you bothered you for even a second?

Kaalaa Baunaa takes a tentative step forward.

Kumar: Locate me? Hahaha. You are still as naive as a child, my Kaalaa Baunaa. You little dummy owl. That is simply impossible.

Kaalaa Baunaa: This is the first time you doubt my capability.

Kumar: No, why would I do that? Of all the students, you are the only child who is smart enough to follow my steps this far.

Kumar: You just don't have time on your side and need a better mindset in dealing with the unexpected.

Kumar: I've tried to teach it to you. Remember those impromptu speeches I asked you to give? Those were good practice.

Kaalaa Baunaa: "Don't have ..." What do you mean?

Kumar: Perhaps you have put too much stock in the idea that I will rely on Manus Vindictae in this. Instead, I trust myself more than them. And, of course, I also trust you.

Kumar: What's more, they were never good enough for me. But luckily, I have never been a real arcanist or a real human, only pretending to be either of them when necessary. I can easily act like an arcanist to gain their trust, just like I could act like a human when I was teaching at Banner.

Kumar notices that Kaalaa Baunaa has been staring at the old finderscope.

Kumar: What are you staring at? Take it if you're interested.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...!

Kumar takes off the finderscope and throws it lightly to Kaalaa Baunaa. It lands precisely on her palm.

The surroundings remain the same. Kaalaa Baunaa can't find any loopholes at all.

Kumar: What? You thought it is the key to cracking the Meditator's Realm, like those stone statues earlier?

Kumar: Though it is too late for hints, there is one thing I have to remind you of.

She is indeed as thoughtful as she claims to be.

Kumar: You didn't catch up to "the real me," nor did you improve the situation by entering the Realm. You chased me all the way here, chased the hope of "winning" against me, but you only helped me complete my plan.

Kumar: The moment you entered the Realm, the last step of my plan was done.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I completed what?

Kumar: As you know, exerting influence on reality through the Meditator's Realm is challenging. After all, this Realm is like the shadow of its real counterpart, a reflection of reality.

Kumar: I went to a lot of trouble, even wasted a statue, to finally stick out a corner of the shadow over the boundary of the two worlds.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You mean the statue in the cave ...

Kumar: Yes.

Kumar: What I needed was an outside-in force to break the Realm, which is almost unbreakable from the inside.

Kumar: A mirror can reflect objects, but there's nothing it can do to itself. It can only be shattered into pieces by people not from the reflection, but reality.

Kumar: Whenever there is a shooting star streaking across the sky of this Realm,

Kumar: an equally beautiful star will fall on the real earth!

Kumar: And guess what? YOU are the force I'm looking for.

Kaalaa Baunaa: No. How?

Kaalaa Baunaa: So the fluctuation I detected, the energy of the celestial body felt by the Foundation girl ... are just false alert?

Kumar: Oh, no, I have to admit, that young girl was not part of my plan. But, at least, you are on the right track about what happened!

Kumar: If anything is to blame, it's your ego. You were trying to win, but not by saving people. The idea of proving yourself to me outweighed their lives.

Kumar: You must be wondering, "How could she lay such a trap with her insignificant arcane power"?

Kumar: "She can barely lift a lump of clay. She must have had the Manus Vindictae on her side to help!"

Kumar: All that being said, you don't have to feel yourself to be a lesser version of me. You're still my best student, my best colleague, and my strongest rival—well, with some room to improve.

Kumar: Even this time, you didn't lose the game for lack of wits, but for the fact that I know you a bit better than you know me,

Kumar: and I simply have more experience hunting a prey.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You and the Manus ... I've never, never thought that.

Kaalaa Baunaa feels her explanation is meaningless and stuck in her throat. She's almost choking for breath in the gentle breeze.

Kaalaa Baunaa: That means if I didn't enter the Realm to see you ...

Kumar: Then things are going to be tricky for me. You would be enjoying a happy Dīpa Festival, while I would be crying in a dark corner nobody knows of.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Why? Why would you ...?

Kumar: Well, time's up. Remember to ask the most important question first next time, child.

Kumar: Don't thank me for that suggestion, and don't think too much of my kindness. I didn't explain all these things for your sake. I told you everything, because only by doing so can I enjoy the victory to its fullest. Your desperation is a good prize for me.

Kumar: You know I have a bad taste for entertainment.

Kumar: Go back to the Dīpa Festival. At least there's one good thing left for you—you will get to see that beautiful shooting star with your own eyes, just like I will.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...!

Kumar: Goodbye.

3#10

Rat and Its Days

JMP-11

Kanjira: Hmm. My ankle hurts no more!

Kanjira tries to move the tightly wrapped ankle.

Kanjira: ...

Shamane is sitting under the sacred fig, and Matilda is anxiously walking round and round the vat. Neither of them is in the mood to check Kanjira's ankle.

Matilda: She's been in there for, emm, 4 minutes 26 seconds.

Matilda: Is this a reasonable length of time? I remember I once learned about the ideal time length for meditation in one of the elective classes.

Matilda: What's more, she's holding her breath underwater.

Shamane: ...

Shamane closes his eyes.

The noise of people, the footsteps, and the light cracks coming from the inside of the tree gradually turn into the crackle of flames.

When there is only one way to the destination, you have no choice but to take it.

Pain is coming from his scar of the mutilation, which healed up long ago.

You have to force yourself to take that painful step, and then blame yourself for being such a desperate fool to move and lose balance.

Who has never made a mistake?

There was a time when he was just like them.

If he had chosen the other path, the sacred fig wouldn't have died, and they would be sitting in its shade.

Shamane: ...

But who says that would be the better future?

Shamane: ...

But the silver lining is, it's just a stagger on the solid ground.

And you will eventually regain your footing.

Kaalaa Baunaa: *coughs*

The vat bursts into pieces after the five-minute silence. The water splashes onto the ground, like strange shadows cast in all directions.

Matilda: ...! Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa!

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...!

The poor vat breaks into pieces. The muddy liquid spreads in all directions and covers the ground.

Her wet hair is clinging to her tightly. She looks as miserable as a drowned rat.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Leave here. *coughs* Now, and get everyone.

She vomits in great pain, as if she could expel the regret from her body this way.

Matilda: Did, did you see Kumar?! What happened?

Kaalaa Baunaa: I'm the one to blame. D**n it!

Shamane: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: I'm such a fool. I should have known that I'm not a match for Kumar.

She knows what that means. If the boundary between the Realm and the reality is broken, that celestial body will fall on them in no time.

There's no easy way to forgive herself.

Maybe it will destroy them today, maybe in the next minute.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Keep telling myself I did all these things to save the people, to save the village. Turns out it was me fighting against a dummy she set up!

Kaalaa Baunaa: I messed up everything for everyone.

She looks at her fingers. The nails have sunk into the soft ground.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

A wrinkled piece of coarse cloth comes into her sight.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I'm sorry.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I should have listened to you.

She lowers her head even more.

Kaalaa Baunaa: If I were more sensible and just left this path, this stupid d**n "trap," nothing would have turned out this way.

Shamane: ...

Shamane: Oh, is that how you see it?

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Shamane: I assume you think it this way because you have failed in the mission and thus feel depressed and indulge yourself in some negative thinking.

Shamane: Which is totally understandable. Blaming it all on yourself, telling yourself you will be the only one to suffer the consequence so as to alleviate the guilt. Or, you didn't understand what I said to you earlier at all.

Kaalaa Baunaa: What?

She looks up with confusion, wondering if that relaxed tone is another illusion.

Shamane: You have to stop it, Kaalaa Baunaa. Remember what I said? "You don't have to feel bad for trusting people." And here's another piece: Don't blame yourself for being brave.

Shamane: What did she tell you? "You're a fool, and you ruined everything"?

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

He crouches down and looks straight at his reflection in her eyes.

Shamane: Come on! Both of us know this is not the case.

Shamane: Brave or reckless, prudent or cowardly ... Comments like these could be predictions, but most of the time are hindsight.

Shamane: The good news is, we still have time to change that.

Shamane: You know what kind of bears the hunters fear the most? The ones which were once trapped but eventually got away.

Shamane: Nobody can remain a predator forever. We don't know what will happen in the next encounter. What's more ...

Shamane: Life is a long fight where we outsmart one opponent and get outsmarted by the other. That's the wisdom of nature! Bears eat salmon; wolves eat rabbit; but eventually, bears or wolves, their skin will become our blankets.

Shamane: A tiger might have strength, yet a rat also has its wits. You don't need to defeat her to validate your victory. You can win this war in another way, a way to your advantage.

Shamane: When will the wrestling between a fisherman and a fish begin? When the fish bites the bait.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Shamane: So, if you still have some strength left in you to get back on your feet and think straight, that'd be most helpful. After all, I don't think we have the time for another round of meditation.

Kaalaa Baunaa takes the cloth.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

She buries her face into it, wiping hard across her eyes—the pain brings her senses back.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: The last time I wiped my face with this, I was wrestling with my mom.

She takes a deep breath, trying to get her brain working again.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kumar ... She broke the boundary between the Meditator's Realm and reality through me. I'm afraid the falling star will arrive early.

Matilda: What?! There's no other way to stop her, then?

Kaalaa Baunaa: There might be a way to stop her by locating her in person, but I didn't spot any clue in the Realm. And now ...

Shamane: We are in a dangerous situation, almost as urgent as the time when Rama was facing the arrow nocked to a full bow. Instead of getting caught up in nostalgia, we should take action and protect what can be saved.

Matilda: The estimated arrival time of the Foundation backup is 6 a.m. It will be too late if the meteor really falls early.

Matilda: We need a shelter that can withstand the impact! Also, we have to gather all the villagers.

Matilda: And, and ... Ah! In the field training, the instructor also told us to ...

Kanjira: I'll go with you!

Kanjira staggers her way to them.

Kanjira: I'll go with you. I know the way better! Besides, Sherjah is not back yet.

Kanjira: If anything happens to she, I will not forgive myself I say those words.

Matilda: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Hmm.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I'm staying.

Kanjira: Hmm?

Kaalaa Baunaa: If I can calculate the range of damage of the comet, we may retreat to a safe location.

Kaalaa Baunaa flings her wet hair back.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Every rat has its day.

Kaalaa Baunaa: And "this rat" is doing her best.

Shamane: Hahaha! Don't put on a face like that. You are not some rat, I can tell! You are the tiger cub. In the meantime, let's not forget—the real rat is still out there looking smug!

It is predictable that there will be a long-term battle outside the stone door enchanted with protection incantations.

Shamane turns around and rubs his hands, feeling a bit uneasy.

Shamane: Watch out for the things I knock off. I didn't do it on purpose!

3#1

Straws Against the Wind

JMP-12

Street

Ms. Sherjah: *exhales*

The last butter lamp has been blown out by the quiet breath.

Darkness falls on the people who are still in hiding.

Ms. Sherjah: We are safe as long as they can't find us.

Sherjah hides the fainted woman and the girl in the shadow to keep them safe.

Jina: *sobs* Ms. Sherjah, I'm scared.

Jina holds Sherjah's hand so tightly, as she is the only lifesaver now.

Ms. Sherjah: Relax, Jina. Remember what Dad and Grandpa said? Just wait here, and they will be back soon. Your brother is also helping them out.

Jina: *sobs* But those monsters are terrifying. Even, even Mother ...

Ms. Sherjah: Hmm.

Recalling the tragic scene, Sherjah can't help closing her eyes.

Ms. Sherjah: Mother just passed out. Don't worry. She will ...

Rajesh: D**n it! F**king monsters!

Manus Disciple: AAARRRHHHH!

The man casts an incantation while wielding the ram-dao to keep the monsters away.

Takal: Humph! Filthy maggots!

Rajesh: Father! There are still a lot of them.

Takal: Don't be such a coward, Rajesh. Be a man! Humph! Can't believe we are even counting on a human girl now.

The ram-dao cuts through the air. An arm covered in black slime falls to the ground.

Manus Disciple: UUUGGGHHHH!

Takal: Shame on us! *coughs*

Rajesh: Father, watch out!

Manus Disciple: AAARRRHHHH!

Ms. Sherjah: Sir! Watch your back!

The body acts before the mind. The moment Sherjah exposes herself and rushes into the light, her senses scream to warn her of the danger.

Ms. Sherjah: ...!

Manus Disciple: EEERRRHHHH!

There is no doubt a bare-handed human challenging a group of Manus followers is throwing straws against the wind.

Shamane: Hah!

The last Manus follower falls to the ground, the mask broken in half.

Shamane freezes, his fist still in the air. Even he himself doesn't realize what has happened.

Shamane: Oh, boy! That was close!

He looks down and meets Sherjah's equally confused eyes.

Shamane: Ah, Ms. Sherjah, I admire you for your courage, but this is getting a bit too nerve-racking.

He withdraws his arm, a bit scared by what has happened.

Kanjira: Ms. Sherjah!

Ms. Sherjah: Kanjira? Wait, how did you find this place?

Kanjira: Sorry, Ms. Sherjah. I should not is mad at you! That scares me so ...

Ms. Sherjah: S-Sorry. I couldn't control myself, and my body just ...

Takal: Hmm? Wait, young man!

The old man grasps Shamane's left arm.

Takal: This arm ... You! You are the Sharma boy!

Shamane: Hey! Aren't you Uncle Takal? It's been such a long time since we last met!

Takal: How, how did you ...

The old man seems to be looking at a living ghost.

Shamane: Oh, Uncle Takal, I wish I could talk to you for a bit more, but the situation seems to be less than ideal.

Warmly greeting the old man, he avoids the question.

Shamane: To put it simply, this place is about to be smashed into an impact crater by a meteor. Even worse, the meteor will arrive here sooner than the Foundation's rescue.

Shamane: But, among all the unfortunate people, you are the lucky ones! You are the first group we found.

Shamane: Come on, get in, we will have a get-together at my place. Uncle Takal, you remember the way to our house, right?

Takal: What?! That burned old house?! No way! I will never ...

Shamane: Well, I will have to apologize to you for this then, Uncle. You must come with us, even if I have to tie you up and drag you there.

Takal: No! Stop it! You deviant brat!

The villagers are pushed into the tuk tuk with their complaints.

Shamane: Alright. I'm glad to see that you're fine, Ms. Sherjah. We are in dire need of a helping hand.

Kanjira: Ms. Sherjah, I remember you know this place well!

Ms. Sherjah: Yes, I do.

Shamane: We need to transfer everyone here—humans and arcanists—to a safe place.

Kanjira: And you're the best person to do that.

Ms. Sherjah: I ...

Ms. Sherjah: ...

Ms. Sherjah: Alright. I'll do whatever I can, as long as it helps.

Shamane: Wish my father could see this. Isn't she a lot more reliable than I am?

Shamane: Told the old man a million times that humans make more decent work partners than arcanists. *sighs*

Matilda: Hurry up, you people!

Matilda opens the door and urges them to get in.

Matilda: You can chat later!

Shamane: I hear you. Sherjah, please briefly tell us what the neighborhood is like. We need to pick up everyone in the town as soon as possible.

Shamane: We need to find the quickest way to do it and avoid all the enemies on the way.

Shamane: Hey, relax. We can't run away from them—we will just run over them!

3#1

Open Sesame

JMP-13

Inside the Sharma Old House

Kaalaa Baunaa: How is everything now?

Ms. Sherjah: Well, it's going smooth. The young people and tourists left as soon as I persuaded them. Only the old and the children are left here. It's not that easy for them to move, and ...

Ajar: Hey, you promised to give me half of it! Now what, the boss cannot keep her own promise?

Kanjira: Humph! I do most messenger work! More food for more work!

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Ms. Sherjah: These kids were abandoned and driven away by humans. I'm glad to see Kanjira get along with them.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa looks down at the astrolabe in her hand.

Kaalaa Baunaa: If she could enjoy a life like this ...

Ms. Sherjah: ...?

Kaalaa Baunaa: No. Nothing.

Kaalaa Baunaa chuckles. There's a faraway look on her face.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You just reminded me of my mother.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Sherjah, perhaps people like you are the key to saving all of us.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I just observed it again. The figures are showing a grim picture. Luckily, I've worked out the specific range of damage.

She draws quite a large circle on the map.

Kaalaa Baunaa: As long as we can get out of this radius, there will be no casualties.

Kaalaa Baunaa: As for other losses ... they are beyond my ability to cover.

Matilda: Emm.

Matilda: The airship of the Foundation is on the way. At least our water supply is secured for now.

Matilda: But the problem is, in such a distance ...

She draws a straight line on the map lightly.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The distance ... Even if we follow the straight line, it is impossible for us, with the elders and the children, to get out of it within hours.

Matilda: Err, why! We are getting so close to success.

Matilda: If only we could go underground ...

Shamane: Underground? Wait!

Shamane: I remember my old man told me about an emergency tunnel leading to the forest on the mountain. Its entrance is right here, beneath the floor of this very room.

Kaalaa Baunaa: A tunnel?

Shamane: He told me this, hoping that one day I will take over his responsibility to look after the village. If I remember it correctly, that forest, which is also the exit of this tunnel, is right outside the impact area.

He taps on a spot outside the marked range with his rough finger.

Kaalaa Baunaa: That's great. In the tunnel, even if we don't make it to the forest in time, we can still avoid the damage.

Shamane: But, but ...

He scratches his beard, hissing in embarrassment.

Shamane: The problem is there's a gate to the tunnel. Now, just for the record, I'm only quoting my old man.

Shamane: "It is a gate which only opens to the leader who has earned his people's trust."

Matilda: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kanjira: Oh, "Open Sesame!" We is going real treasure hunting this time.

Out of the silence, only the naive child is excited.

Shamane: Oh, well. My father's version was hardly as exciting as "Open Sesame"! I didn't believe him even as a child!

Shamane: I tried to open it by force many times. Well, it never worked!

Shamane: If my old man was telling the truth, things would be problematic for us ...

Shamane: Because I don't think I can get that gate open! Firstly, I've never wanted to be a leader, and speaking of "the people's trust" ... How do you think those cursing old men in the yard will feel about me?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Emm.

Kaalaa Baunaa listens to "those cursing old men" for a while. She cannot contradict what he says.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Even so ...

She taps on the map, thinking.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: We will open that gate.

She looks up at Shamane. He is standing in silence and has a blank look on his face.

Shamane: ...?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Even if we have to smash it with our bare fists.

Shamane: ...

Shamane: I'm not sure if you were being sarcastic.

She doesn't give a clear answer. Instead, her eyes flit back to the map.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's the best way in the current situation.

On the porch in front of the house, there is a loose floorboard.

Under it, they see some wooden stairs, which appear to be the entrance of a tunnel.

Ms. Sherjah: Watch your steps.

One after another, they slowly go down the stairs.

In Front of the Stone Gate

The gray and yellow stone gate has a pattern of an elephant raising its front feet in the middle. It is as immovable as a real elephant.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Matilda: So the spell Shamane told us is truly useless.

Shamane: Hahaha, what did I say? This is never the gate for me to open.

Shamane gives them an embarrassed smile. Behind him, the criticism comes as expected.

Takal: Tsk, I knew we shouldn't have counted on you, Sharma boy. You can't even protect your own family. How are you supposed to protect others?

Villager 2: May the gods listen to my prayer and send us another guide ...

Shamane: ...

Oh, here they come again! The complaints Shamane has heard so many times. Those familiar syllables make him almost—nostalgic.

Kanjira: ...

Kanjira is tapping a foot faster and faster—it's getting hard for her to suppress the anger.

Takal: After dealing with humans all these years, we are already ...

Kanjira: ...

Kanjira: You!

Kanjira: SHUT UP YOUR MOUTHS!!

Shamane: ...!

Villagers: ...!

The crowd instantly falls into silence.

The spell of "nostalgia" is broken. Shamane lowers his head, surprised by her irritation.

Kanjira: All you talk about is protect, family, and stuff. Give me a break!

Kanjira: And YOU!

Shamane: Emm? Me?

Shamane points at his own nose, brought up short.

Kanjira: Yes, you!

Shamane: W-what about me?

Kanjira throws back her head and glares at him.

Kanjira: You love talking, don't you? Now you go dumb? Humph! Big guy can't defend yourself!

Kanjira: I just don't understand. You feel bad. You say it. Why is you afraid?

Kanjira: You don't owe them!

Kanjira: See?

Kanjira extends a finger at the hushed crowd.

Kanjira: You talk, and you shut them up!

Shamane follows her pointing finger and looks at the familiar faces.

He suddenly realizes that, after all these years, he still remembers each of them clearly.

Shamane: ...

There is no longer anger or disdain in their eyes. They just remain silent and avoid his gaze.

Kanjira: Why don't you do this earlier? We need to focus on the most important thing!

Kanjira: It's "Open Sesame" story!

Kanjira mumbles admiringly.

Kanjira: In the story, only the most smart and wise people can open it! Why do you hesitate now?

Shamane: Haha ...

Shamane laughs, as if she has said something most amusing.

Shamane: Little one, you think I'm the smartest and wisest person?

Kanjira: Er, no.

Shamane: Oh.

His laugh stops.

Kanjira: But why ask me? It is your gate!

Shamane: ...!

Kanjira: My answer don't matter. Their answer don't matter, too. That's why I said you should shut them up!

Kanjira rolls her eyes.

Kanjira: There will be a gate for me, and I will open it my way!

Kanjira: I'm the one to decide how to open my gate. My spell will be longer and cooler than some "Open Sesame."

Kanjira: I'm not jealous you!

She turns her back to him, refusing to cast a look at him.

Shamane: Haha ... *sighs* Interesting! Looks like Dad was right. I'm not qualified to be a leader.

Shamane: Thanks, kid.

Shamane: Phew!

Shamane: Anyway, times have changed. Forget the spell.

That's his father's gate, his father's path, his father's choice of life, and his father's responsibility.

Shamane: But it is I who am standing here, not him.

He raises his voice.

Shamane: Screw it. I have no idea what my father once promised you. In fact, I have no interest in what your old heads think.

Shamane: Hmm, but what's my own way of opening the gate?

Pick a new spell? Sing a song? Bleat like a goat?

His fist clenches. At this serious, crucial moment, he is strangely relieved by one sudden idea.

Shamane: ...

He doesn't need any implements. He can just do it with his bare hands, figuratively and literally.

Shamane: Hahaha!

Shamane: And the one standing right here right now is me, not another Sharma.

Keep the shoulder loose, stay steady, and engage with the upper arm.

This is his way.

Shamane: That is to say ...

Shamane: Hah!

This is the easiest punch he has ever thrown.

The burden from the past, the pain, and the stress are thrown out of his body at this moment.

Oh! Turns out the gate ...

... is much more fragile than I thought.

Forest on the Backslope

It's a quiet night in the forest. A bonfire is lit in a small, open space.

Ajar: "That is to say, I'll smash that door open, even if it takes the other arm of mine!"

Villager 3: Yes! That's what I'm talking about. So cool!

As the stick pokes the bonfire, a clear snap can be heard.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I guess you didn't see that coming?

Shamane: To tell the truth, I had prepared myself to bounce off from that closed gate, like what had happened many times when I was a kid.

Shamane: But, wow, see how I burst it open? That was cool.

He throws a few punches in the air excitedly.

Shamane: Ho! Ho! Ha ...! Ah!

He takes back his fist, content, and casually pokes the fire.

Shamane: So, in the end, my dad was just telling nonsense to a kid.

The flame is dancing in his eyes.

Shamane: Those so-called profound teachings, like one needs "adequate strength" or "a sense of responsibility" ...

Shamane: Those were too abstract for a kid to understand. Ha, that's indeed his style!

Kaalaa Baunaa: But, in the end, the door was opened. That's for sure.

Kaalaa Baunaa: That's a good ending for a story. At least a million times better than mine.

Shamane: Haha, you have a long way to go before reaching the end! But I'd say you're in a much better place now than you were in the beginning.

Shamane: It's good progress. Trust me.

Observed from the top of the mountain, the old village is only as small as half a palm.

Shamane: He who only stays behind a closed door will turn away many things, including a chance to survive.

Kanjira: Alright, alright! Best roast rabbit ever! Ms. Sherjah, you have the first bite!

Kaalaa Baunaa: A person with no family yet radiates the warmth of family to others.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: *sighs* ... If only Kumar had the slightest warmth from someone, maybe such an absurd thing would have never happened.

Shamane: I doubt she's upset about what happened. Maybe she has found herself a good seat to enjoy this dance of Shiva!

Kaalaa Baunaa: That's true. She is the kind of person who always finds herself the best seat to watch the show.

Shamane: But, I'm curious. Tell me, did she say anything bad about me?

Kaalaa Baunaa: That was not a part of our conversation. She just admitted that she was being vindictive.

Kaalaa Baunaa slightly frowns, hoping to find some clues in the chaotic memories.

Kaalaa Baunaa: "Maybe I was being vindictive out of hatred, like you said."

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

She suddenly jumps up, as if she were burned by the bonfire.

Kaalaa Baunaa: "Like you said"?

Kaalaa Baunaa: The Realm can never extract every word I've said. It's theoretically impossible.

Kaalaa Baunaa: How ... Where-where did she hear that part?

3#1

No Starry Sky

JMP-14

Kaalaa Baunaa: She was in the same room?

Kaalaa Baunaa: How could it be?

Kaalaa Baunaa pinches herself to keep calm.

Shamane: I know that room well. We have searched every inch of it—Unless she was hanging on the ceiling right above us.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But, as I said, she always finds herself the best seat.

Kaalaa Baunaa: "To be someone who can smile knowingly at the argument made by the lecturer, knowing full well the thinking process behind, while staying close to other whispering opinions."

Kaalaa Baunaa: "Like a perfect observatory from which we witness the events in the universe."

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

The fog has lifted.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Maybe I've been in the wrong direction. She didn't make the star fall as revenge on the village.

She looks up. The sky is completely cloudless, and the stars look just like the silver sand randomly scattered into the Samudra by Vishnu.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The sky in the Realm when we met ...

She recalls the sky in the Realm, which was like the surface of dusted glassware.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Mr. Shamane, she was not on the ceiling.

Shamane: Are you taking me seriously? That was just a joke to lighten up the mood.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But, under the ground.

Shamane: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa pulls a photo slowly from her waist. It was soaked when she was in the vat, but now it is almost dried by the bonfire.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Remember the Underground Survival Guide, where we found this photo? She's right under that house.

The street is empty. All the villagers have been evacuated. There are only Manus followers wandering about at night.

Kaalaa Baunaa: First, to the corner ...

And the ones who have returned.

Shamane: This is crazy. It has gone beyond my imagination!

Kaalaa Baunaa: Sorry, but you don't have to come with me.

Shamane: *sighs* Say no more on that.

The two sneak from one corner to another.

Shamane: If you don't let me see my own sister, I will be dying for answers! Who would dig a basement here?

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: That reminds me. Her curiosity is one of the, well, the major reason she did that.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's possible that she was well-prepared last time she came back to Mor Pankh. I never thought she foresaw that we would be kicked out from the project.

Shamane: And as you just deduced, she did so to see that star?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Almost 100% sure. Without me, she must have asked the Manus to support her with arcane skills.

Kaalaa Baunaa: This way.

After avoiding the wandering Manus followers, they can almost see the entrance to the old house.

Kaalaa Baunaa: She was extremely mentally unstable when she left me. It wouldn't take any effort if the Manus had the intention to recruit her.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Watching the meteor shower and being destroyed by it has been her plan all along.

Shamane: At this point, it is hard to say who is worse, she or we, since we have prepared to die with her evil plan. However reluctant I am to admit this, sometimes arcanists are indeed strange creatures.

Shamane: Heh heh ... It's like a madhouse party! Hahaha!

Shamane: But what did you teach Matilda before we left?

Kaalaa Baunaa: That's our only chance to survive in her Realm. I came up with it when I was calculating the range of the fallen star damage.

Shamane: ...

Shamane: As I said, you are the tiger cub, trying to take a bite in the arm, even when the hunter has had you in her grip.

Kaalaa Baunaa: That method was between Kumar and me. There is another theory according to my calculation: if there are more observers, the Realm might collapse.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's the only theory Kumar doesn't know. At the same time, it is not yet strictly verified.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But I have faith in that girl. She is indeed a genius.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I hope it's not too late to make our last attempt.

Shamane: Hmm, if you ask me, it's not yet the time to make that attempt.

Kaalaa Baunaa: What?

They are only one step away from the old house.

A huge Shiva statue rises with the loud rumble.

Shamane: Haha! This must be the appetizer she served us.

Shamane: *sighs* Great Shiva, I hope your fists feel as light and crispy as pani puri when they land on my body!

Kaalaa Baunaa: *pants* That's tough.

Shamane: Hey, look over there!

The statue's attack has left a crack in the floor of the old house.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It is empty down there.

3#1

Feast for the Savant

JMP-15

???: ♪

Radio: The shower is estimated to fall at 4 a.m. today. By then, the comet will also ...

???: Three and a half hours to go. Oh, almost forgot about this—music.

???: ♪

Basement

In this dark, confined space, there arises a melody played on the violin.

The place looks nothing like a livable space for humans.

The walls, the table, the floor ... Every surface in sight is covered with paper of seamless formulas. The only exception is a roughly plastered wall, which is full of symbols marking the passing of days.

An old telescope is standing in the mess, pointing at the blocked sky.

Shamane: *coughs* You alright?

Kaalaa Baunaa: I-I'm fine. It's not too high for me.

They slide down through the crack.

Kaalaa Baunaa gets back on her feet, patting the dust off her.

And then, she freezes.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kumar!

Kaalaa Baunaa: What ... what happened to you?

Kumar: Oh, well. I didn't expect so many visitors.

She seems a bit absent-minded.

Kumar: But since you're here, please take a seat. I built this place by myself. It's not a big room and not soundproof.

Kumar: Yes, I heard you very clearly under the ground when you searched the room and went through my stuff. What's wrong about an astronomer reading "Calf Feeding and Management"?

She paces around shakily, muttering to herself.

Kumar: You ... you should have left. Hmm, my plan has chan- ... changed.

Kumar: ...

Kumar: Let it be. Let it be. What do they call this? Destiny? You know about destiny, right, Kaalaa Baunaa?

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kumar: Watching the stars with me. Good, good. It's like living the old days again.

She turns around. Her gaze falls on Shamane.

Shamane: Kumar. Sister.

Kumar: ...

Kumar: Haha. Sister. Sister ...

A fleeting sneer appears on her lips.

Kaalaa Baunaa frowns deeply.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You looked much better in the Realm. What did the Manus do to you?

Kumar: The Manus? Oh, they're fine. Helps me a lot. Impressive arcane skills, experiment apparatus, and food—lots of food.

Following Kumar's fingertip, they see a pile of naans in the corner, which are under a layer of unknown insects.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: These are ...

Shamane: Seems like she's no longer capable of commanding those wandering Manus.

He would have panicked, but he is calm this time.

He reminds Kaalaa Baunaa in a whisper.

Shamane: But the priority is to stop that star. We can deal with the rest ...

Kumar: The star? You're going to stop the comet. You are taking it from me? Again?!

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kumar. Argh!!

Kumar, who was absent-minded a second ago, seems to be triggered now. She suddenly pushes the two out with enormous strength.

Kumar: I will never ...

The confined space starts melting.

Shamane: ...!

The basement is no longer there.

Instead, the space opens up, unfolding before them like the vast universe. Nebulas are churning beneath their feet, like a colorful, harmless mist.

Kumar stands in the void, like standing in the middle of a grand stage.

Kumar: I will never let anyone set their hands on it!

3#14

The New Stargazers

JMP-16

Shamane: *pants*

Shamane: I-I'm gonna throw up. It feels strange in here.

Shamane feels his legs weaken. He sinks to the floor.

Shamane: ... Was that Master's face?

Shamane: I-I can keep up.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's hard to get used to it for the first time.

Though panting unstably, Kaalaa Baunaa is still staring at Kumar, who has regained elegance in the Realm.

Kumar: I feel a lot better in here. I'm sorry, Kaalaa Baunaa. I don't think this body of mine can hold any longer for a more appropriate meeting in the real world.

Kumar: I'm glad you came back for me. What I said was indeed too harsh.

Kumar has turned back to herself.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kumar, why do you have to ...? Look at you. The price is too high.

Kumar: ...

Kumar: Hmm, in the first instance, I did have other intentions.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kumar: I kept imagining how my so-called "parents" would react when they were about to get crushed to pieces by the star.

Kumar: Little did I know, they have already paid for what they've done.

Kumar casts a quick glance at her puking brother and looks back at Kaalaa Baunaa.

Kumar: I worked myself to the bone, but who knew I would lose everything, including my purpose? It really sucks.

Kumar: But it's okay. Just a minor setback. Compared to what I've been through, it's not even worth mentioning.

Kumar: That's why I changed my mind.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kumar: I want to see it.

Kaalaa Baunaa: To see it? The star we can't see with our eyes?

Kumar: Seems like I was not very careful about my wording when my mind was clouded.

Kumar: It is a celestial body, Kaalaa Baunaa, not a star. It could even be a ... moving black hole.

Kumar lifts her palms, like she has done so many times in Kaalaa Baunaa's inquisitive gaze and in the lecture hall of the university.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: I'd rather you did this out of the hatred towards the people who abandoned you, or even towards me ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: ... for I carelessly exposed my identity as an arcanist, and thus you lost your ...

Kumar: I wish the same. I wish so badly that I could just be filled with pure hatred towards someone. But I can't, kid.

Once again, Kumar looks at Shamane. He still feels dizzy.

Kumar: You're the lucky one, young brother. I was going to kick your butt in our last encounter, but ... I just couldn't do it.

Shamane: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: But the Manus has made you ...

Kumar: Kid. Banner University can get my name on the SCI list, while the Manus allows me to touch the universe. They are not that different to me.

Shamane: Sister, Mother told me about this. You physically can't take such a great amount of arcanum in you! The Manus should also know this!

Kumar: I appreciate that they remembered this about me, but this is the path I chose.

Kumar looks down at the swirling nebula.

Kumar: When I look into the sky, I feel myself the freest being in the world.

Kumar: The universe, what a vast, life-embracing place it is! No matter if you're an arcanist, or a human, even a grain of sand ... it encompassed everything.

Kumar: But I was driven away from studying it, abandoned by my own family, for some insignificant, unimportant reasons.

Shamane: ...

Kumar: I should have understood this earlier ... that my struggle means nothing on this planet.

Kumar: I'm tired, Kaalaa Baunaa. I just want to see that celestial body with my own eyes.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But, Kumar ...

Kaalaa Baunaa tries to stare into her eyes.

Kaalaa Baunaa: That's not how you look at a star. The telescope shouldn't be placed in a basement, and you shouldn't lower your head.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kumar, how long has it been since the last time you looked up at the night sky, at the other stars?

Kaalaa Baunaa: What's more ...

Kaalaa Baunaa looks grave.

Kaalaa Baunaa: If the star falls, people in the village, including those kids—none of them will survive.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The Manus you summoned here has brought disaster to this place, to the people and their families.

Kaalaa Baunaa: They are not the sacrifice of your wish.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Stop heading down the wrong path, Kumar.

Weariness reigns over Kumar.

She raises her eyebrows and shakes her head slowly, as if nothing matters to her anymore.

Kumar: ...

Kumar: You know what? I don't care about them.

Kumar: Just like they've never cared about me, have they?

Kumar denies her, like she did when Kaalaa Baunaa pitched a terrible research proposal.

Kumar: Sorry, please indulge me with one last willful act.

As Kumar raises her arms, the stars in the Realm form a straight line.

Kumar: This is the path I chose.

Kumar: And you can't stop me, Kaalaa Baunaa.

Kumar: Hmm?

Clear cracks come from the depths of the universe, one after another.

Kumar: What?

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's Matilda! They made it!

Matilda: Hurry! Quickly! Do you understand? Yes, that's what Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa taught me to do.

Kanjira: Hmm. But I can't see anything when my eyes are closed.

Matilda: Don't rely on the eyes. Hold this crystal and take a deep breath.

The kids sit next to Matilda, forming an imperfect circle by the fire.

Outside this little circle, the human kids are peering around curiously.

Under the starry sky, the ones sitting by the fire take a deep breath and put their hands on a small idol.

Kanjira: To feel, emm, what she said?

Passer-by Boy: The change of the universe.

The starry sky is completely quiet.

Matilda: ...!

Matilda: The meteor shower is starting earlier!

Kumar: What did you do?

Kaalaa Baunaa: *coughs* That's the method only once known between you and me, Kumar.

Kumar: The observation method?

Kumar: You told others about the Celestial Egg?

Kumar: So wh- ...

She stops herself.

She's always the clever one.

Kumar: I see, I see. You once pitched that research proposal to me.

An almost gratified look appears on her face.

Kumar: You are indeed my best student, Kaalaa Baunaa.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: I finally understand why you asked me to keep it a secret. Even if we named it Egg, it's actually a projection of the universe, which has the same feature.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The universe is infinite, as long as we observe it self-consciously, think each of ourselves as one of the centers of the universe.

Kumar: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: The Egg will then collapse because of multiple centers, until it puts a quietus on everything, including that star.

Kaalaa Baunaa: A shattered mirror will never be pieced together again, if there are enough forces to break it. Am I right?

Kaalaa Baunaa: *"Then there was neither existence nor non-existence; there was neither the realm of space nor the sky beyond."*

Kumar: ...

Kumar: Who could master these skills? Those old fogeys in the village?

Kaalaa Baunaa: A genius girl and a bunch of kids who looked up at the stars.

"Just like you and me in the beginning."

Kaalaa Baunna's lips quietly move, but none of those words come out.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I'm sorry, Kumar. I have to—no, we have to—stop you this time.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I can't let you destroy Mor Pankh ...

They are not enemies. At least for now, this is not a confrontation.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ... or destroy yourself.

3#1

Neither Day Nor Night

JMP-17

Shamane: It's about to collapse! Got to go now.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kumar! KUMAR!!

She extends her arm as far as possible, reaching for that figure.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Ah!

A giant rock falls between them. Kumar is lost in her sight.

The shabby basement has completely collapsed. Moonlight floats down through the ceiling that no longer exists.

Kaalaa Baunaa: *coughs*

Kaalaa Baunaa: Mr. Shamane, you covered me.

He pats the dust off his shoulder.

Shamane: I'm fine.

He looks in the other direction.

Shamane: ...

Kaalaa Baunaa follows his gaze and sees Kumar.

Kumar: Pretty ...

The ragged woman with gray hair looks up slowly at the night sky.

Several meteors are crossing the sky with glaring tails.

Kumar: ...

Shamane: Her Realm has gone, taking that falling star with it.

Shamane: Tonight, only the meteor shower will sparkle in the sky.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kumar. Kumar!

Kaalaa Baunaa, who is now also ragged, staggers toward the one staring at the night sky.

She's haunted by an ominous feeling.

Faster, even faster, get to her side like she used to ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kumar.

Finally, Kaalaa Baunaa holds Kumar's hands.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I'm still here, Kumar. How about we ... go back first?

Kumar: Go back?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Yes, go back to the institution, to the university ...

She cannot continue.

Kumar: It seems Kumar can no longer understand her words. She just frowns and stares at her in confusion.

Kumar: ...

Kumar: Suddenly, she relaxes her eyebrows and smiles while shaking her head.

Kumar: There's no place I can go back to.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Yes, there is! You can stay at my place. You can use my lab. We can start over.

Kumar: ...

Kumar: Sure.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Really? You will? Let's go then! Leave this place first.

Kaalaa Baunaa gets up quickly and holds Kumar's arm in hers. She drags Kumar to leave, seemingly afraid that Kumar may change her mind.

Kumar: But there are some papers I need to take with me. Let go of my arm.

Says Kumar behind Kaalaa Baunaa. She sounds quite relaxed.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Okay.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Somehow, Kaalaa Baunaa dares not look back. She can only look up at Shamane's face.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Mr. Sharma, Kumar says she'll come with us! She just needs to take some papers. It won't take long!

Shamane: He slowly shakes his head.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Shamane never feels this calm. He looks at his sister, but he feels he is looking at someone else.

He is looking at a weary soul waiting for her final salvation.

She is his last kin.

And he is going to respect her decision.

Kumar: *"Then there was neither death nor immortality; there was neither day nor night."*

Kumar: Everyone has a place to go back to. What a nice world to live in.

Kumar is familiar with the space, even if it's a ruin now. She reaches a corner and takes out a black gadget.

It is the only item she has ever asked from Manus Vindictae.

And now, for the second and the last time, she places her hand on it.

Kumar: I hope ... when the universe constructs me for a second time, I will not come to this world again.

Bang!

Chandigarh Night Market

Ajar: Wow! So this is what Chandigarh look like! It slay!

Passerby: What's this? Candy?

Ajar: This way. Come over here.

The once rugged paths have been turned into smooth roads. In this new city, the villagers still carry on their old customs.

Candles have lit up every street for the new immigrants on this spring night.

Shamane: Ah. So you're only an assistant! No wonder they made you go through so many procedures earlier.

Kanjira: Haha. What? So you is just rookie?

Matilda: Shut up! I won't allow another word of it! Humph, you'd better be careful; otherwise, you will regret your doings when you get to the Foundation!

Kanjira: Heh heh.

Matilda: Did you just make a face to me? Stop right there!

Foundation Member: Ms. Sherjah and Mr. Sharma.

Foundation Member: Thank you so much for helping our staff.

Ms. Sherjah: Emm, you flattered me. I just did what I could.

Foundation Member: No, madam, we've ascertained your achievement.

Foundation Member: Before this incident, you volunteered to help over 10 arcanists and human children, and this time you rescued more than 30 arcanists.

Foundation Member: That's remarkable, madam.

The woman in the Foundation uniform seems to be smiling at Sherjah and passes over a gray envelope.

Ms. Sherjah: What's this ...

Foundation Member: A letter of introduction to the St. Pavlov Foundation.

Ms. Sherjah: ...!

Foundation Member: I'm sure you know our branch in Chandigarh is already under construction. Such a responsible and caring human member like you will be very welcome.

Foundation Member: Please do consider this opportunity.

The Foundation member rummages through the materials in her hand.

Foundation Member: According to the record, there's one more arcanist who also provided help for us in this mission.

Foundation Member: So, where is Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa?

Ms. Sherjah: Oh, she's ...

Sherjah turns around. Kanjira is gone too.

Ms. Sherjah: That's weird.

Ms. Sherjah: Oh!

She suddenly realizes something.

Ms. Sherjah: I think it's not a good time for her.

Foundation Member: ...?

Ms. Sherjah: They will be back after the meteor shower.

Kanjira: Ah! Meteor shower! So many of they as the news mention!

Kanjira: Hmm. I wish I can have my stomach full every day when I go school!

Matilda: Let me be an investigator, even for once!

Shamane: Alright, people, don't be greedy! One wish only!

Kaalaa Baunaa: Goodbye, Kumar.

3#2